CHESS HANDOUTS

SERGEY V. POPOV

# BEGINNER

22 lessons · 120 puzzles · Solutions on page 43

**Name:** _____ **Club / group:** _____

## Colour Key

**Basics**
How the pieces move and the must-know mates

**Attack**
Going for the King

**Defence**
Staying safe and stopping threats

**Strategy**
Plans for the middle of the game

**Endgame**
Few pieces left: finish the job

**Openings**
The first moves and good habits

**Rules**
Tournament rules and good manners

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Most handouts are followed by a puzzle sheet. Tick them off as you go!

Some puzzles come from real games on lichess.org

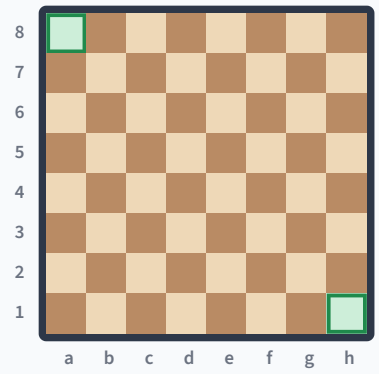
# SETTING UP THE BOARD

The board, the pieces and where they go

**Lesson 1 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. The Board

LIGHT SQUARE ON THE RIGHT

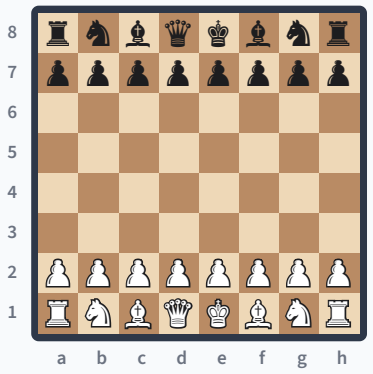



`64 squares: 8 rows × 8 columns`

- Turn the board so each player has a **light square in the bottom-right corner** (h1 and a8).
- Rows are **ranks** (1–8), columns are **files** (a–h).

## 2. The Starting Position

16 PIECES EACH

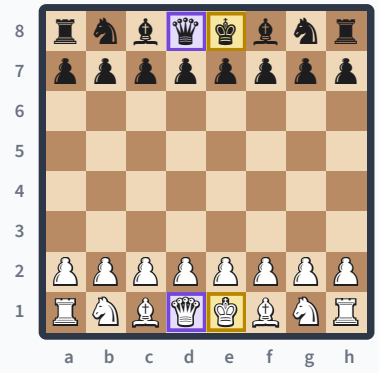



`R N B Q K B N R`

- **Rooks** in the corners, then **Knights**, then **Bishops**, then Queen and King in the middle.
- **Pawns** fill the whole next row: rank 2 for White, rank 7 for Black.

## 3. Queen on Her Colour

KINGS FACE EACH OTHER




`White Queen d1 · Black Queen d8`

- The White Queen stands on a **light** square, the Black Queen on a **dark** square.
- The Kings go next to their Queens on the **e-file**, facing each other.

## 4. Meet the Pieces

NAMES & VALUES

| Piece | Name | Letter | How many | Worth |
|---|---|---|---|---|
|  | **King** | **K** | 1 | Priceless |
|  | **Queen** | **Q** | 1 | 9 |
|  | **Rook** | **R** | 2 | 5 |
|  | **Bishop** | **B** | 2 | 3 |
|  | **Knight** | **N** | 2 | 3 |
|  | **Pawn** | `(none)` | 8 | 1 |

- The Knight is **N**, because K is already taken by the King.
- "Worth" helps you decide if a trade is good: a Rook (5) is worth more than a Bishop (3).

## Set-Up Checklist

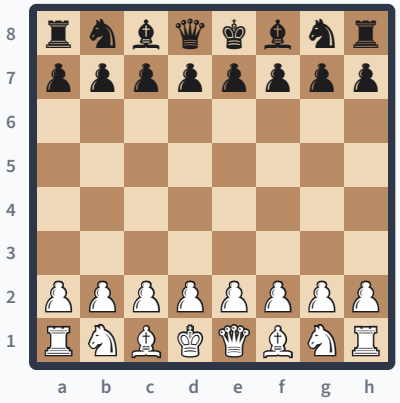
1. **Light on the right:** the bottom-right square (h1) must be a light square.
2. **Queen on her colour:** White Queen on the light square d1, Black Queen on the dark square d8.
3. **White always moves first.** Then players take turns, one move each.

# PUZZLES: FIND THE MISTAKE

Each board has ONE set-up mistake… or maybe none!

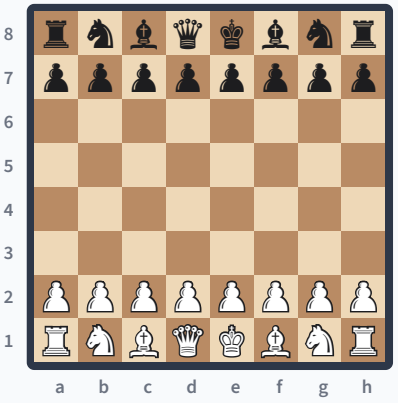
**Lesson 1 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** What is wrong with this set-up?



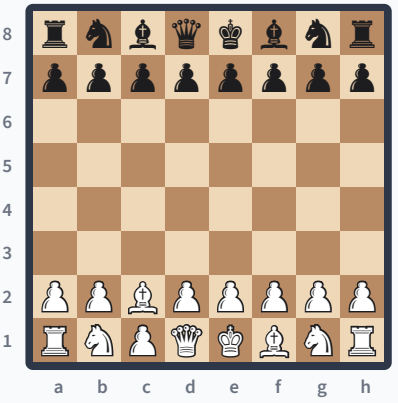
Answer:

**2** What is wrong with this set-up?



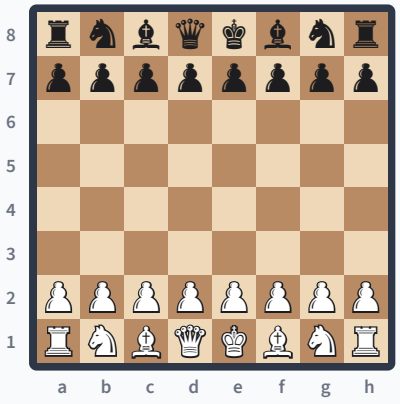
Answer:

**3** What is wrong with this set-up?



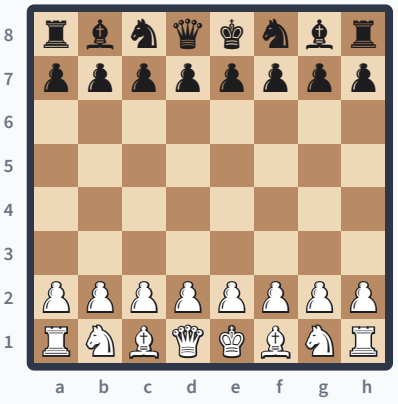
Answer:

**4** What is wrong with this set-up?



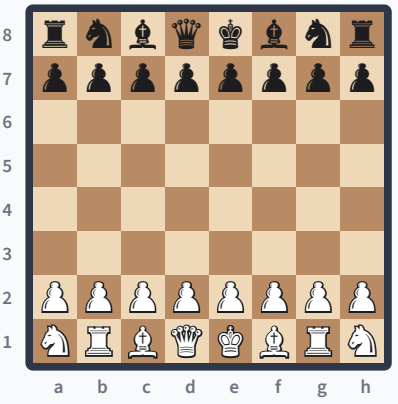
Answer:

**5** What is wrong with this set-up?



Answer:

**6** What is wrong with this set-up?



Answer:

**Tip:** check the corner square first, then the Queens, then each piece from the corners inward.

**Score: ____ / 6**

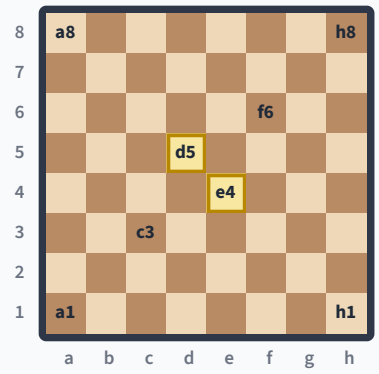
# WRITING DOWN YOUR GAME

Chess notation: every square and every move has a name

**Lesson 2 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Every Square Has a Name

LETTER + NUMBER

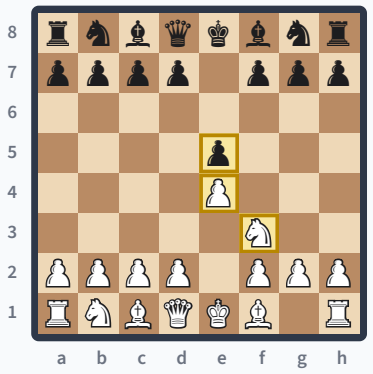



`e4 = file e, rank 4`

- Say the **letter** (file a–h) first, then the **number** (rank 1–8).
- White's pieces start on ranks 1 and 2, so a1 is always White's bottom-left corner.

## 2. Writing a Move

PIECE + SQUARE




`1.e4 e5 2.Nf3`

- **Nf3** = Knight moves to f3. Write the piece's letter, then the square it goes to.
- Pawn moves are just the square: **e4**. Each move number has a White move and a Black move.

## 3. Special Symbols

X + # O-O

| Symbol | Means | Example |
|---|---|---|
| `x` | captures | `Bxf7, exd5` |
| `+` | check | `Qh5+` |
| `#` | checkmate | `Qxf7#` |
| `O-O` | castles kingside (short) | `O-O` |
| `O-O-O` | castles queenside (long) | `O-O-O` |
| `=Q` | pawn promotes to a Queen | `e8=Q` |
| `!` | a good move | `Nd5!` |
| `?` | a mistake | `h6?` |
| `??` | a blunder (big mistake) | `Nf6??` |

## 4. A Scoresheet

SCHOLAR'S MATE

| Move | White | Black |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | e4 | e5 |
| 2 | Bc4 | Nc6 |
| 3 | Qh5 | Nf6?? |
| 4 | Qxf7# | |
| 5 | | |
| 6 | | |

- One row per move number: White's move on the left, Black's on the right.
- Write the result at the end: **1-0** (White wins), **0-1** (Black wins) or **½-½** (draw).

## Why Write Your Moves?

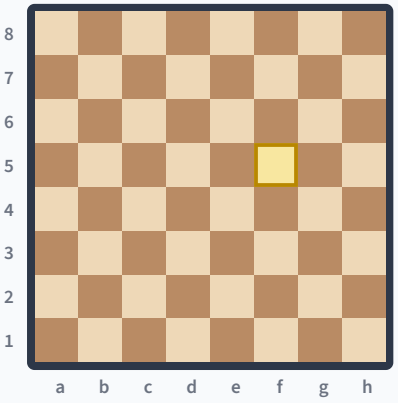
1. **Learn from your games:** replay them at home with your coach and find the mistakes.
2. **Tournaments need it:** in most tournaments you must keep score of every move.
3. **Move first, then write:** tournament rules say make your move on the board, then write it down.

# PUZZLES: SQUARES & MOVES

Read the board, write it down

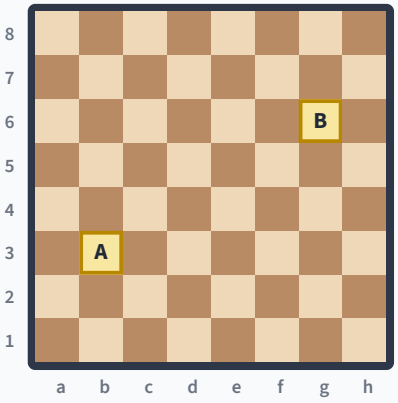
**Lesson 2 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **Name the yellow square.**



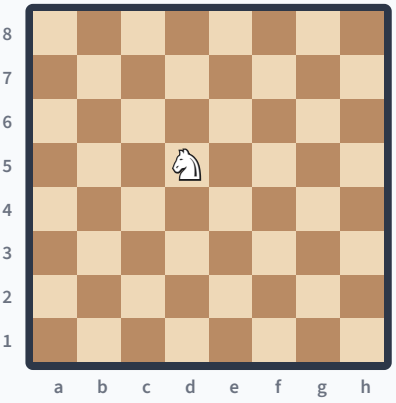
Answer: _____

**2** **Name the squares marked A and B.**



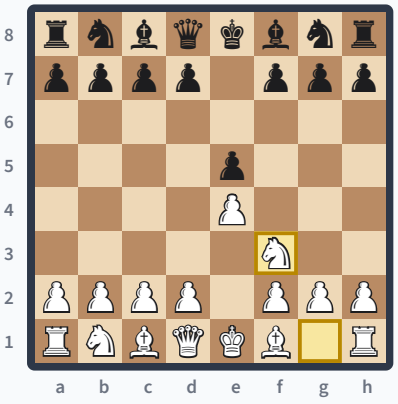

Answer: _____

**3** **On which square is the White Knight standing?**



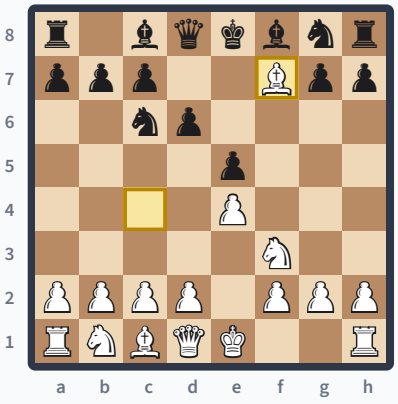
Answer: _____

**4** **White just moved (yellow squares). Write down the move.**



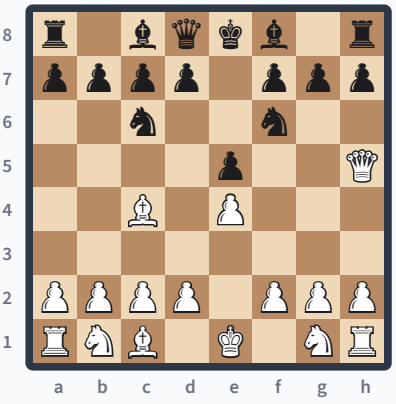
Answer: _____

**5** **White captured with check (yellow squares). Write the move with x and +.**



Answer: _____

**6** **1.e4 e5 2.Qh5 Nc6 3.Bc4 Nf6?? What is White's winning 4th move?**



Answer: _____

**Tip:** letter first, then number. Use the labels on the edge of each board to help.

**Score: ____ / 6**

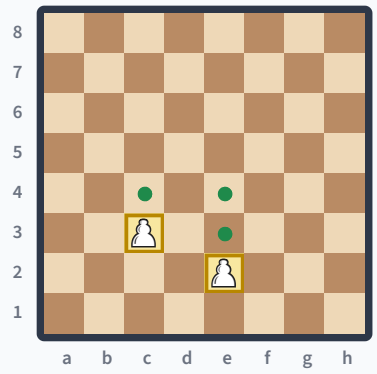
# THE PAWN

Small but brave • It can become a Queen!

**Lesson 3 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Straight Forward

1 STEP (2 AT THE START)

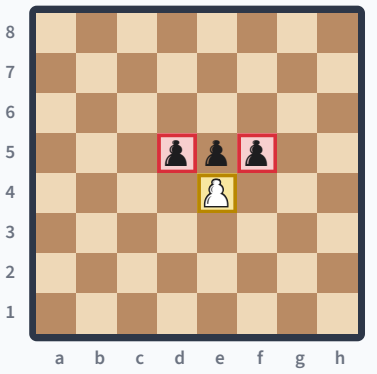



`e2: to e3 or e4 · c3: to c4 only`

- A pawn moves **straight forward one square**. It can never go backwards.
- On its **very first move** it may jump two squares (e2–e4).

## 2. Captures Diagonally

EXD5 OR EXF5

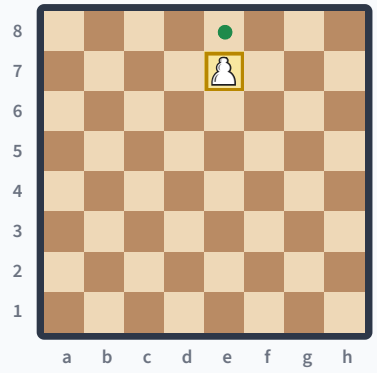



`e4 can take d5 or f5, not e5`

- Pawns capture **one square diagonally forward**, a different way from how they move.
- A piece straight in front **blocks** the pawn: it can't move or capture straight ahead.

## 3. Promotion

LAST ROW = NEW PIECE

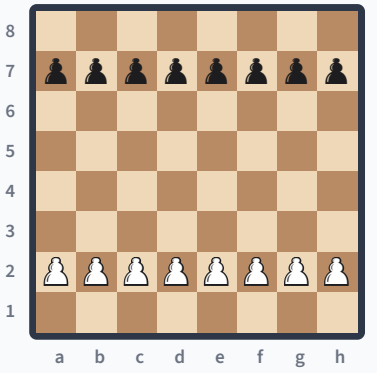



`e7-e8 = a brand-new Queen!`

- A pawn that reaches the **last row** must turn into a Queen, Rook, Bishop or Knight.
- Almost always choose the **Queen**, the strongest piece (more in Lesson 10).

## 4. Game: The Pawn Game

8 PAWNS VS 8 PAWNS




`Only pawns. White moves first.`

- All the normal pawn rules apply, including the two-square first move.
- Rules for winning are in the box below.

### Pawn Game Rules

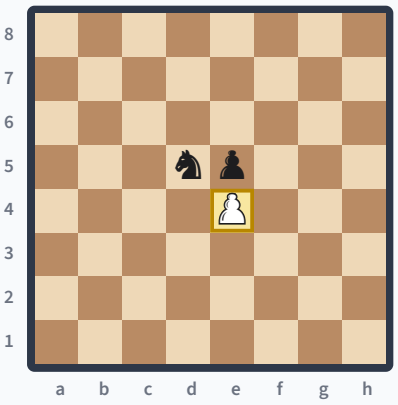
1. **To win:** get one pawn to the other side, OR capture all of your opponent's pawns.
2. **Next game:** the loser plays White (moves first) and removes one of the winner's pawns before starting.
3. **Tip:** pawns side by side protect each other. A pawn with no enemy pawns in front of it is a runner!

# PUZZLES: THE PAWN

Moves, captures, races and promotion

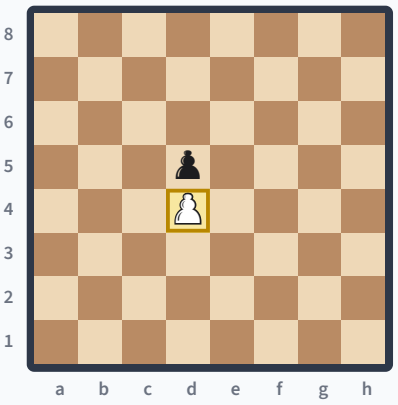
**Lesson 3 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **Which capture can the White pawn make? Write it down.**



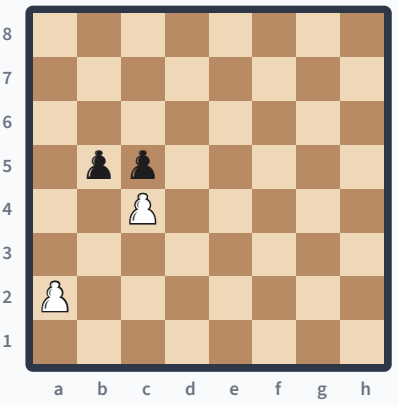
Answer:

**2** **Can the White pawn move? Why or why not?**



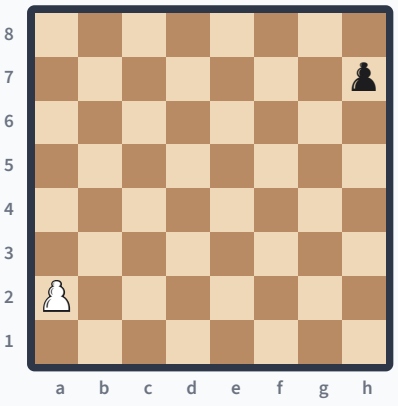
Answer:

**3** **How many different moves can the White pawns make? List them.**



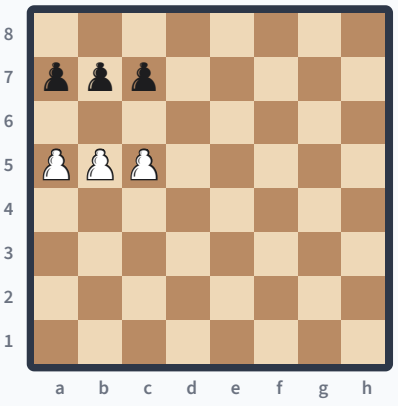
Answer:

**4** **Pawn race! White to move. Who promotes first?**



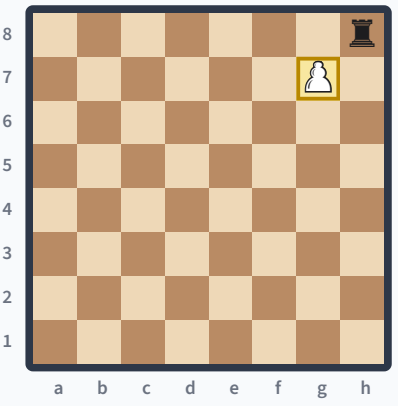
Answer:

**5** **Pawn Game: White to move and WIN!**



Answer:

**6** **White to move. What is the best promotion? Write the move.**



Answer:

**Tip:** White pawns move UP the board, Black pawns move DOWN. Count moves carefully!

**Score: ____ / 6**

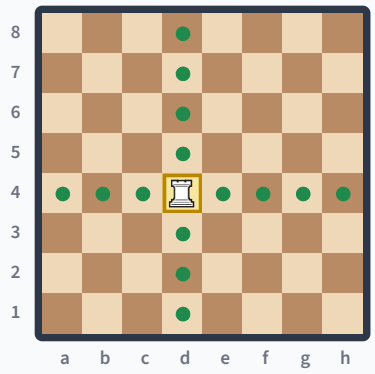
# THE ROOK

The castle tower • Straight lines, as far as it likes

**Lesson 4 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Straight Lines

UP, DOWN, LEFT, RIGHT

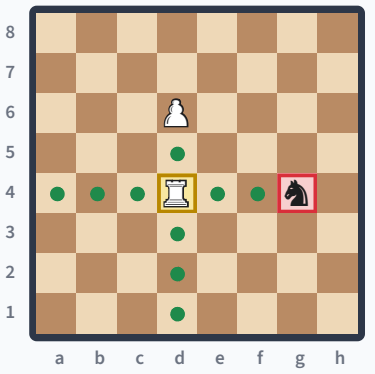



`Rook on d4: 14 squares to go`

- The Rook moves along its **rank** (row) or its **file** (column), as many squares as it wants.
- It never moves diagonally.

## 2. Blocked & Captures

RXG4

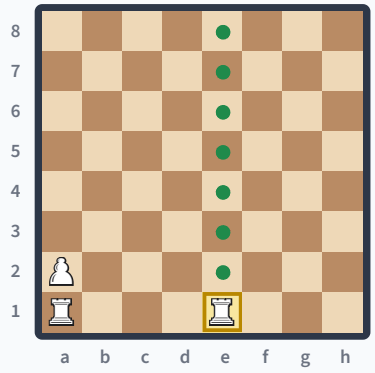



`Own pawn on d6 · enemy Knight on g4`

- Rooks **can't jump**. Your own pawn on d6 blocks the way up.
- To capture, land on the enemy's square (**Rxg4**). The Rook can't go past it.

## 3. Rooks Love Open Files

NO PAWNS IN THE WAY

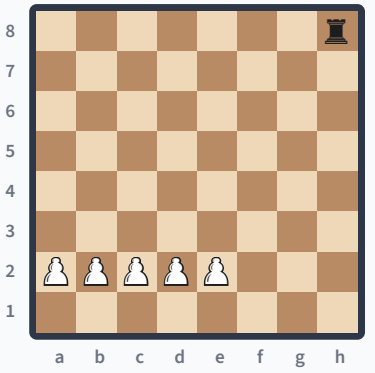



`e1-Rook: the whole e-file`

- The **a1**-Rook is stuck behind its own a2-pawn: it can't go up at all.
- The **e1**-Rook sits on an **open file** and can reach all the way to e8.

## 4. Game: Rook vs. 5 Pawns

CATCH THEM ALL




`Pawns a2–e2 · Rook h8`

- The pawns (White) move first. No Kings in this game.
- Play twice and swap sides: who is better, the Rook or the pawns?

### Rook vs. 5 Pawns: Rules & Tips

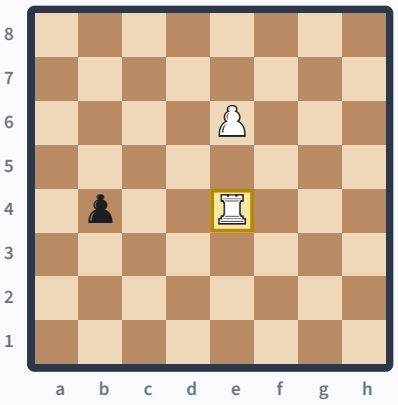
1. **To win:** the Rook must capture all 5 pawns. The pawns win if one of them reaches the last row (or if a pawn captures the Rook!).
2. **Rook tip:** attack pawns from behind or from the side, and only take a pawn that isn't protected.
3. **Pawn tip:** march side by side so every pawn is protected. A lonely pawn is an easy snack.

# PUZZLES: THE ROOK

Straight lines, free pieces and the ladder

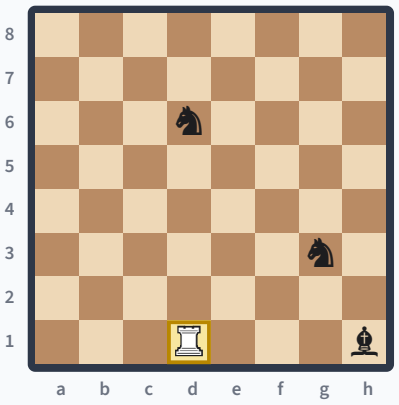
**Lesson 4 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** How many squares can the Rook move to? Count captures too.



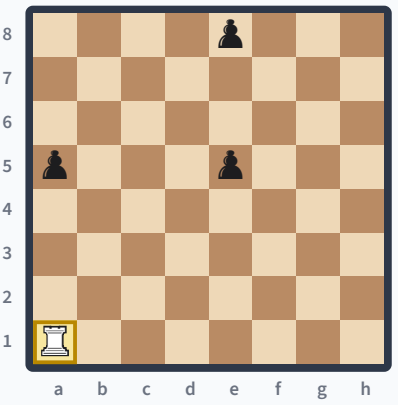
Answer:

**2** White to move. Which Black piece can the Rook capture for free?



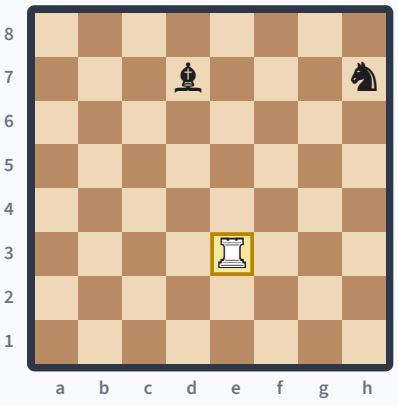
Answer:

**3** Black stays still. How many Rook moves to take all 3 pawns?



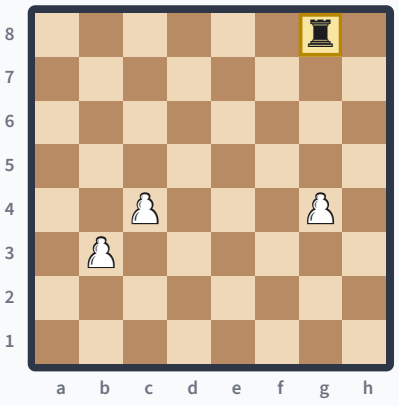
Answer:

**4** White to move. Find the Rook move that attacks BOTH Black pieces.



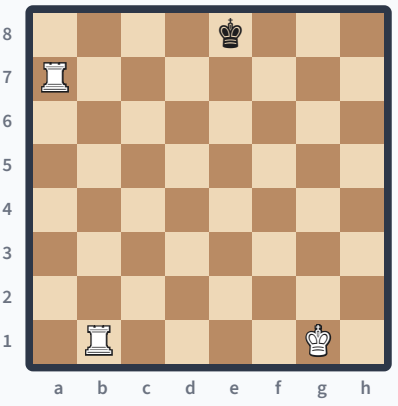
Answer:

**5** Black to move. Which pawn can the Rook take safely?



Answer:

**6** White to move. Checkmate in 1 with the ladder!



Answer:

**Tip:** before you take, check if the piece is defended. A Rook (5) for a Knight (3) is a bad trade!

**Score: ____ / 6**

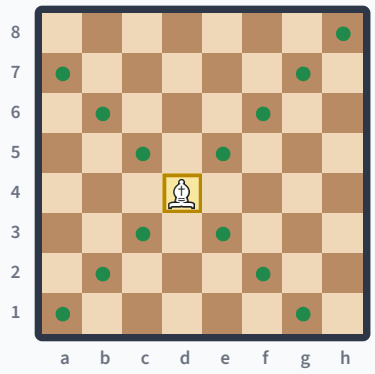
# THE BISHOP

Diagonals only • It stays on one colour forever

**Lesson 5 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Diagonal Lines

4 DIRECTIONS

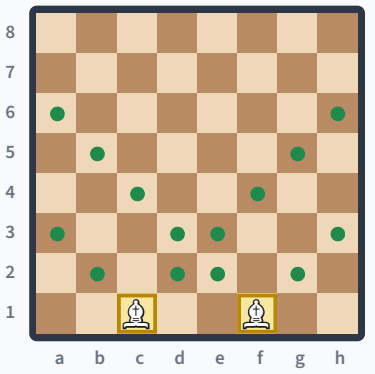



`Bishop on d4: 13 squares to go`

- The Bishop moves **diagonally**, as many squares as it wants.
- It never moves straight up, down or sideways.

## 2. Light & Dark Bishops

ONE OF EACH

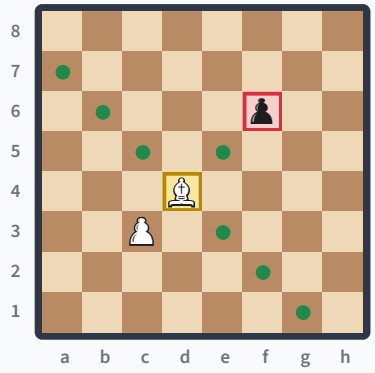



`c1 = dark squares · f1 = light squares`

- Each side starts with one **dark-squared** and one **light-squared** Bishop.
- A Bishop keeps its colour **all game**, so it can only ever reach half the board.

## 3. Blocked & Captures

BXF6

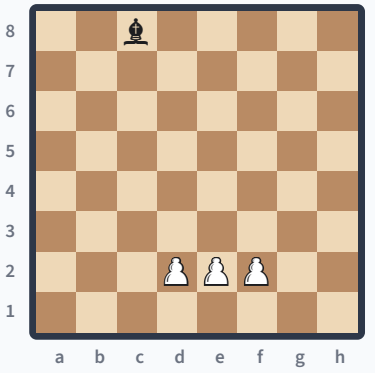



`Own pawn on c3 · enemy pawn on f6`

- Like the Rook, the Bishop **can't jump**. The c3-pawn blocks one whole diagonal.
- It captures by landing on the enemy's square: **Bxf6**.

## 4. Game: Bishop vs. 3 Pawns

CATCH THEM ALL




`Pawns d2, e2, f2 · Bishop c8`

- The pawns (White) move first. No Kings in this game.
- Play twice and swap sides.

## Bishop vs. 3 Pawns: Rules & Tips

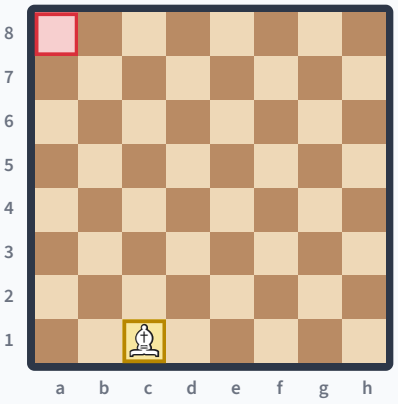
1. **To win:** the Bishop must capture all 3 pawns. The pawns win if one reaches the last row (or captures the Bishop).
2. **Pawn tip:** the c8-Bishop only sees **light** squares. A pawn standing on a **dark** square is completely safe from it!
3. **Bishop tip:** get in front of the pawns early and guard the light squares they must cross.

# PUZZLES: THE BISHOP

Diagonals, colours and double attacks

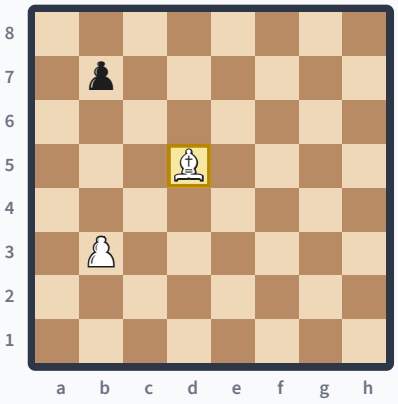
**Lesson 5 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **The Bishop is on c1. Can it EVER reach a8? Why?**



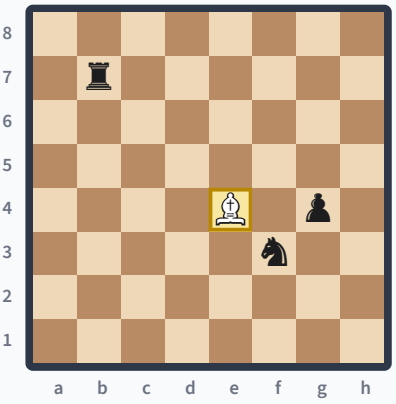
Answer:

**2** **How many squares can the Bishop move to? Count captures too.**



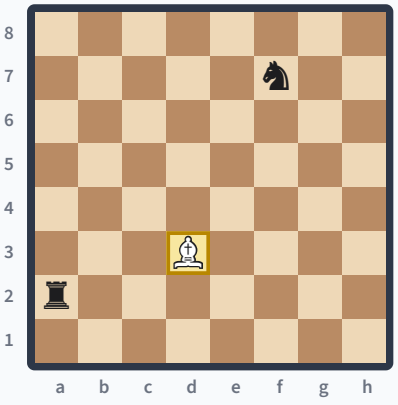
Answer:

**3** **White to move. Which Black piece can the Bishop take for free?**



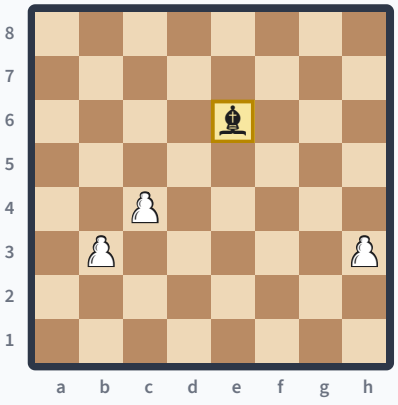
Answer:

**4** **White to move. Find the Bishop move that attacks BOTH Black pieces.**



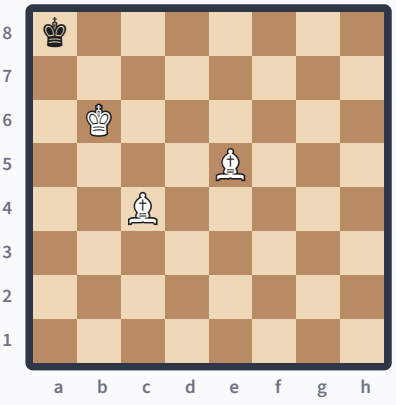
Answer:

**5** **Black to move. Which pawn can the Bishop take safely?**



Answer:

**6** **White to move. Checkmate in 1 with the two Bishops!**



Answer:

**Tip:** trace each diagonal with your finger until it hits the edge or a piece.

**Score: ____ / 6**

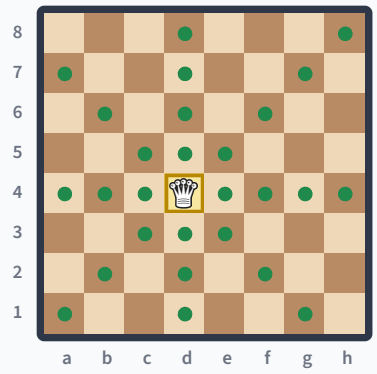
# THE QUEEN

The strongest piece • A Rook and a Bishop in one

**Lesson 6 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Every Direction

ROOK + BISHOP

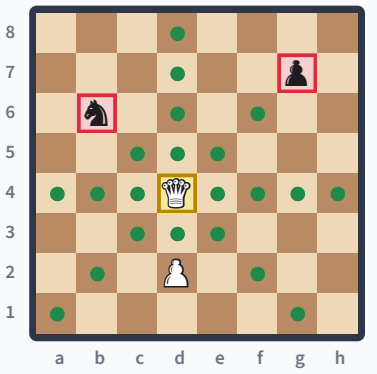


`Queen on d4: 27 squares to go!`

- The Queen moves in **straight lines** (like a Rook) AND on **diagonals** (like a Bishop).
- As many squares as she wants, in any one direction per move.

## 2. Blocked & Captures

QXB6 OR QXG7



`Own pawn d2 · enemies on b6 and g7`

- The Queen **can't jump** either: her own d2-pawn blocks the way down.
- She can capture the Knight on **b6** or the pawn on **g7**.

## 3. Don't Bring Her Out Too Early

WORTH 9 POINTS

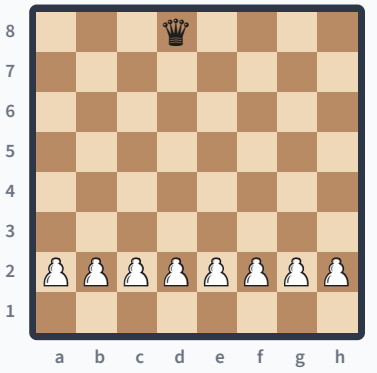


`1.e4 e5 2.Bc4 Nc6 3.Qh5 g6!`

- Because she's so valuable, the Queen **must run away** whenever she is attacked.
- Here a little pawn chases her, and she wastes time while Black develops.

## 4. Game: Queen vs. 8 Pawns

CATCH THEM ALL



`8 pawns on rank 2 · Queen d8`

- The pawns (White) move first. No Kings in this game.
- Play twice and swap sides.

## Queen vs. 8 Pawns: Rules & Tips

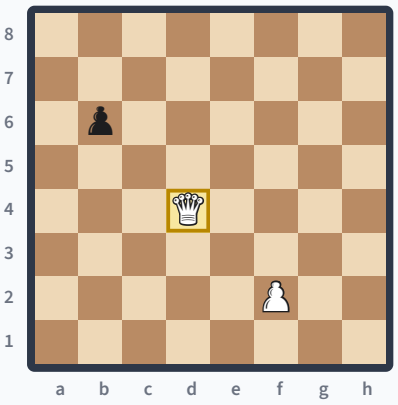
1. **To win:** the Queen must capture all 8 pawns. The pawns win if one reaches the last row (or captures the Queen).
2. **Queen tip:** attack two loose pawns at once (a fork!). Never take a pawn that another pawn protects.
3. **Pawn tip:** move in pairs so each pawn is protected. A protected pawn can't be taken without losing the Queen.

# PUZZLES: THE QUEEN

Power, forks and first checkmates

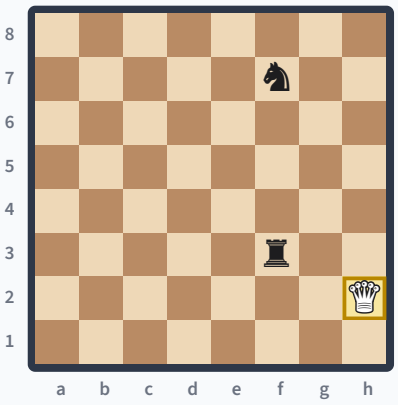
**Lesson 6 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** How many squares can the Queen move to? Count captures too.



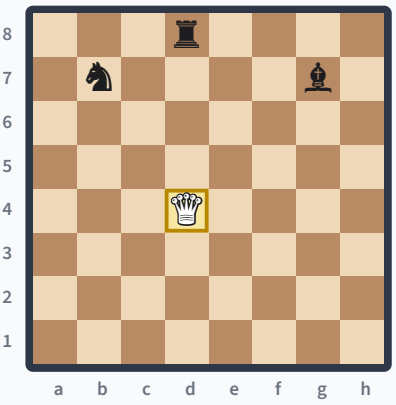
Answer:

**2** White to move. Find the Queen move that attacks BOTH Black pieces.



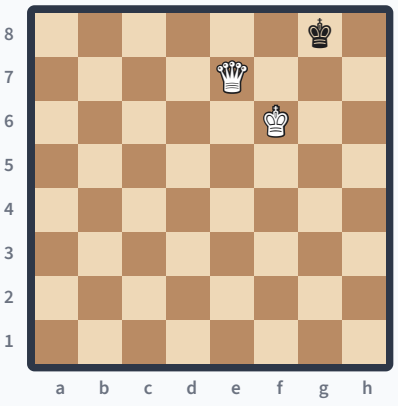
Answer:

**3** White to move. Which Black piece can the Queen take for free?



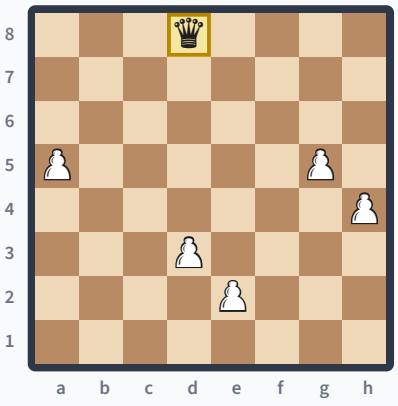
Answer:

**4** White to move. Checkmate in 1!



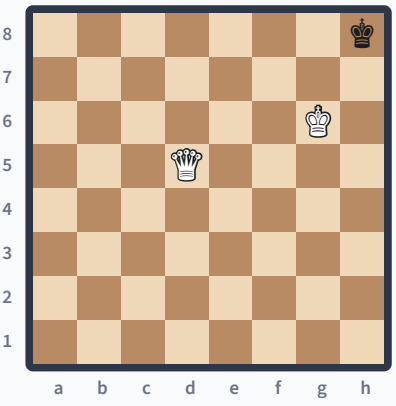
Answer:

**5** Black to move. Which pawn can the Queen take safely?



Answer:

**6** Find TWO different mates in 1. Careful: some moves are stalemate!



Answer:

**Tip:** the Queen is worth 9. Never trade her for something defended and cheaper!

**Score: ____ / 6**

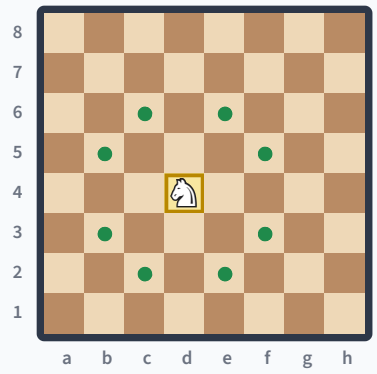
# THE KNIGHT

The horse • Moves in an L and jumps over pieces

**Lesson 7 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. The L-Shape

2 ONE WAY, 1 TO THE SIDE

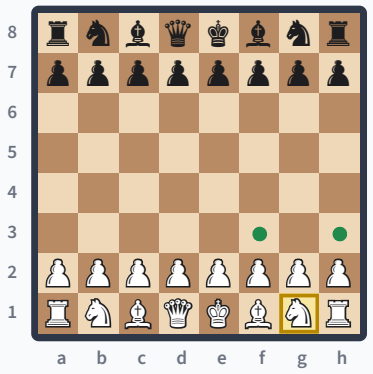


`Knight on d4: 8 squares`

- Two squares in a straight line, then one square to the side: an **L**.
- It lands only on the end of the L, and captures a piece standing there.

## 2. The Only Jumper

OVER THE PAWNS

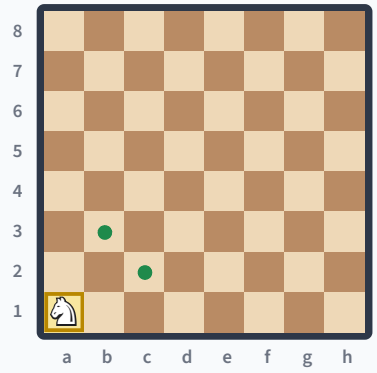


`From the start: Nf3 or Nh3`

- The Knight is the **only piece that can jump** over other pieces, even its own.
- That's why it can move before any pawn has moved. Nf3 is a great first move!

## 3. Knight on the Rim Is Dim

CORNER = 2 MOVES

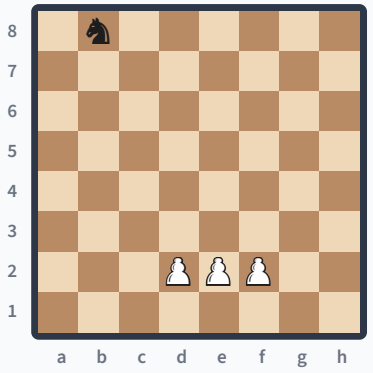


`Knight on a1: only b3 and c2`

- In the corner a Knight has just **2** moves. In the centre it has **8**. Keep Knights central!
- Fun fact: a Knight always lands on the **opposite colour** to the one it started on.

## 4. Game: Knight vs. 3 Pawns

CATCH THEM ALL



`Pawns d2, e2, f2 · Knight b8`

- The pawns (White) move first. No Kings in this game.
- Play twice and swap sides.

### Knight vs. 3 Pawns: Rules & Tips

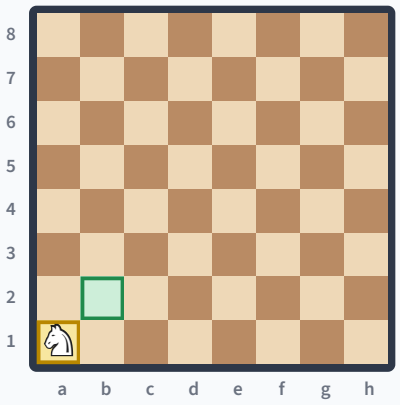
1. **To win:** the Knight must capture all 3 pawns. The pawns win if one reaches the last row (or captures the Knight).
2. **Knight tip:** look for a square that attacks **two** pawns at once: that's a fork!
3. **Pawn tip:** Knights are slow over long distances. Push the pawn that is furthest from the Knight.

# PUZZLES: THE KNIGHT

L-shapes, long journeys and forks

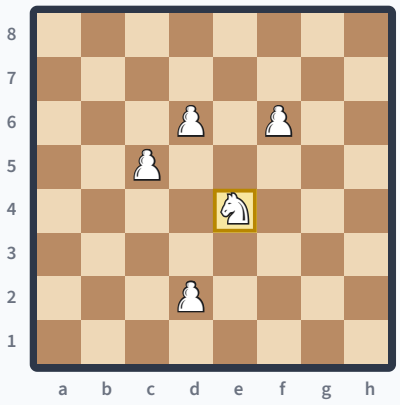


**1** **Knight a1 to b2, right next door. Fewest moves?**



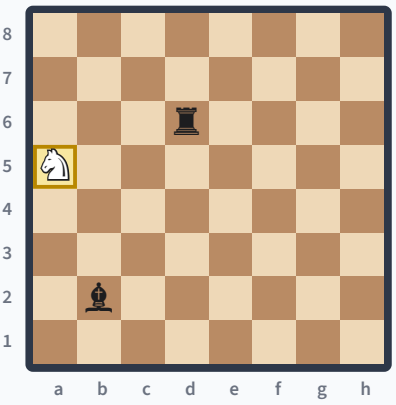
Answer:

**2** **How many squares can the White Knight move to?**



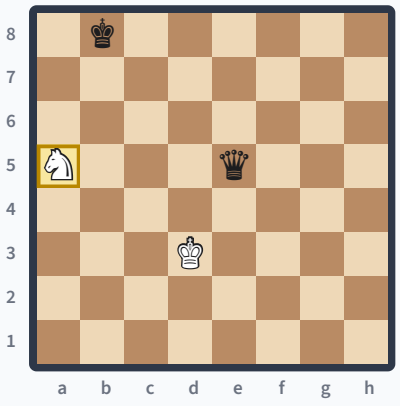
Answer:

**3** **White to move. Find the Knight move that attacks BOTH Black pieces.**



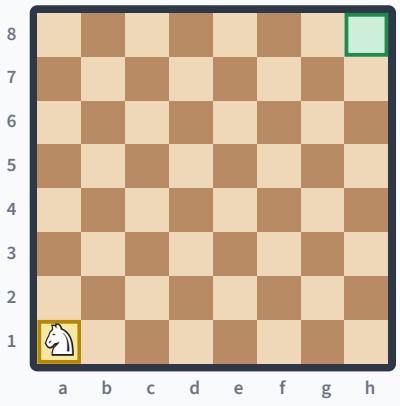
Answer:

**4** **Royal Fork! Check the King AND attack the Queen.**



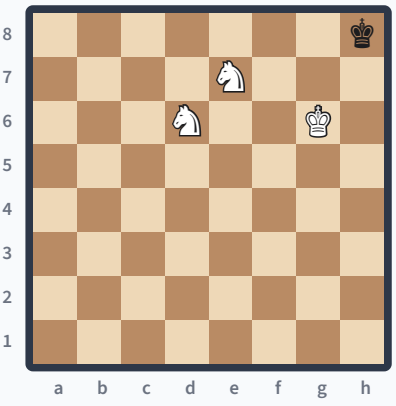
Answer:

**5** **Knight a1 to h8, the far corner. Fewest moves?**



Answer:

**6** **White to move. Checkmate in 1 with a Knight!**



Answer:

**Tip:** a Knight always lands on the opposite colour. Squares next door can be a long way away!

**Score: ____ / 6**

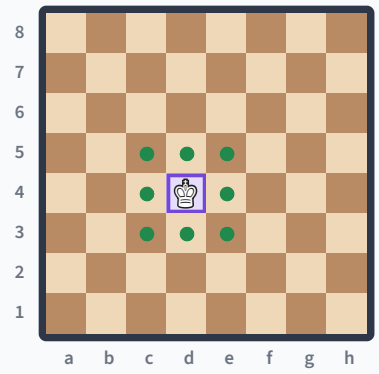
# THE KING

Check, checkmate and stalemate

**Lesson 8 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. One Step at a Time

ANY DIRECTION

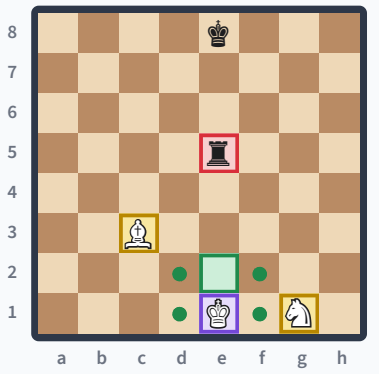


`King on d4: 8 squares`

- The King moves **one square** in any direction.
- It may **never** step onto a square that is attacked, so two Kings can never stand side by side.

## 2. Check: 3 Ways Out

MOVE · CAPTURE · BLOCK

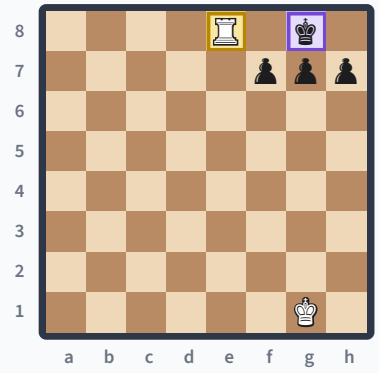


`Kd1 · Bxe5 · Ne2`

- The Rook on e5 attacks the King: that's **check**. You MUST get out of it at once.
- **Move** the King (dots), **capture** the attacker (Bxe5), or **block** the line (Ne2).

## 3. Checkmate

NO WAY OUT = YOU WIN

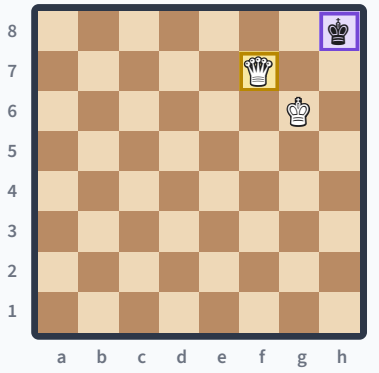


`Re8#`

- In check, and **no way** to move, capture or block: that's **checkmate**. Game over!
- Here Black's own pawns trap the King on the back row.

## 4. Stalemate

NO MOVES, NO CHECK = DRAW



`Black to move: stalemate`

- Black is **not** in check, but every square around the King is attacked, and it has no other piece to move.
- That's **stalemate**: a DRAW, even though White has a whole Queen extra!

## Check, Checkmate or Stalemate?

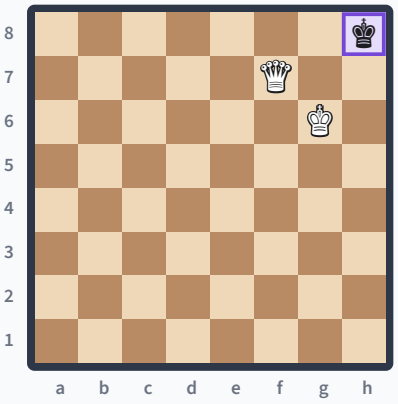
| | Is the King attacked? | Any legal move? | Result |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Check** | Yes | Yes | Get out of check, keep playing |
| **Checkmate** | Yes | No | The attacker WINS |
| **Stalemate** | No | No | DRAW |

# PUZZLES: THE KING

Check, checkmate or stalemate?

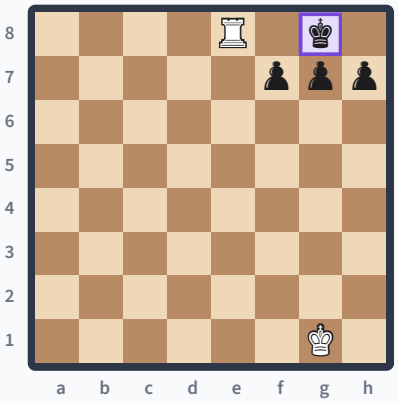
**Lesson 8 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **Black to move. Check, checkmate or stalemate?**



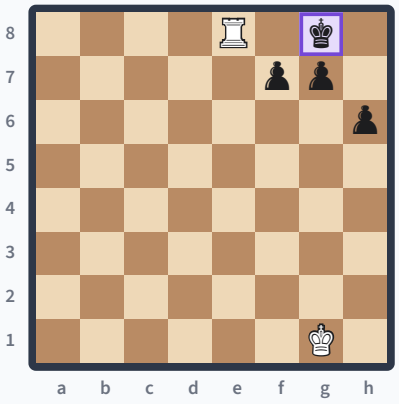
Answer:

**2** **Black to move. Check, checkmate or stalemate?**



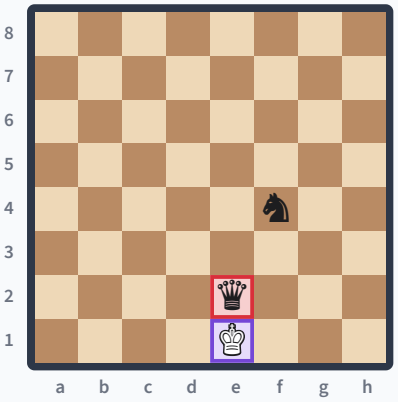
Answer:

**3** **Black to move. Check, checkmate or stalemate?**



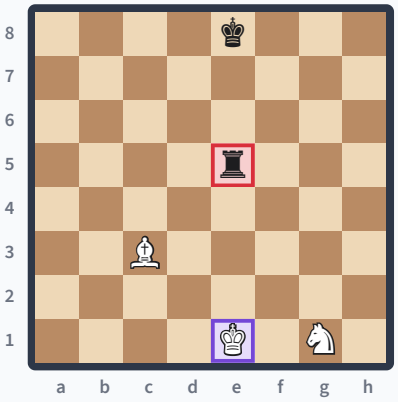
Answer:

**4** **White to move. Can the King take the Queen? What is this?**



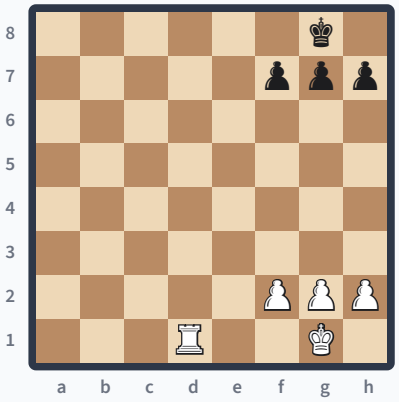
Answer:

**5** **White is in check. List ALL the ways out (there are 6!).**



Answer:

**6** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



Answer:

**Tip:** ask two questions. Is the King attacked? Does the side to move have ANY legal move?

**Score: ____ / 6**

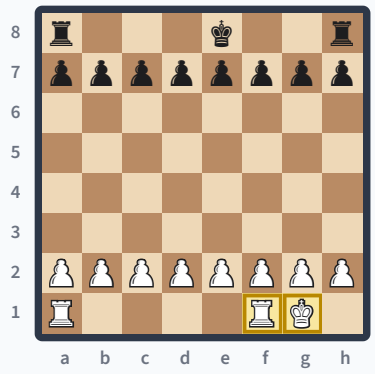
# CASTLING

The only move with two pieces • King safe, Rook in play

**Lesson 9 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Kingside Castling

O-O (SHORT)

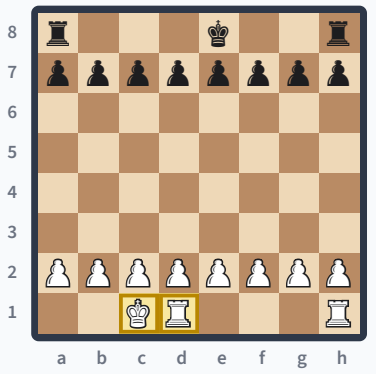


`King e1→g1 · Rook h1→f1`

- The King moves **two squares** toward the Rook. The Rook jumps over to the King's other side.
- Touch the King first. Castling counts as one move.

## 2. Queenside Castling

O-O-O (LONG)

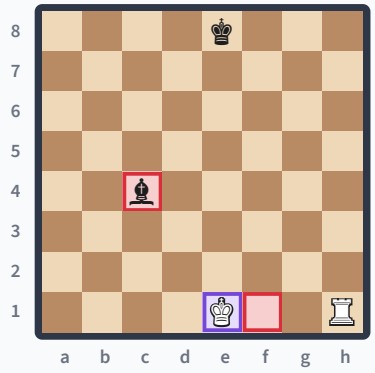


`King e1→c1 · Rook a1→d1`

- Same idea on the other side: the King still moves **two squares**, the Rook lands next to it on d1.
- Here b1, c1 and d1 must all be empty first.

## 3. Not Through Check

F1 IS ATTACKED

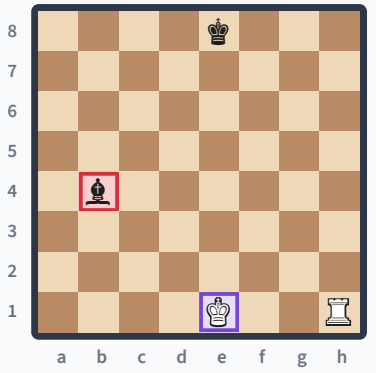


`O-O is NOT allowed here`

- The Black Bishop attacks **f1**, the square the King must cross. No castling!
- The King also may not **land** on an attacked square.

## 4. Not Out of Check

KING IN CHECK



`O-O is NOT allowed here either`

- The Bishop on b4 gives check. You can't castle to escape a check.
- And never if the King (or that Rook) has **already moved**, even if it went back home.

## Castling Checklist: All 5 Must Be Yes

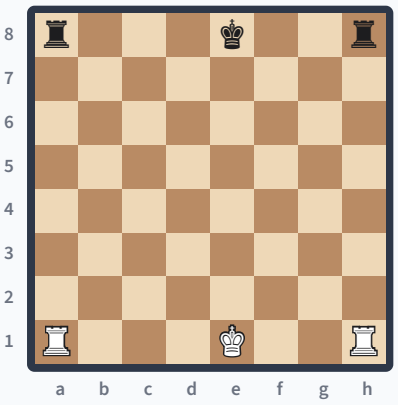
1. The King has **never moved**.
2. That Rook has **never moved**.
3. All squares **between** them are empty.
4. The King is **not in check** right now.
5. The King doesn't **cross or land on** an attacked square.

# PUZZLES: CASTLING

In every puzzle, the King and Rooks have not moved yet

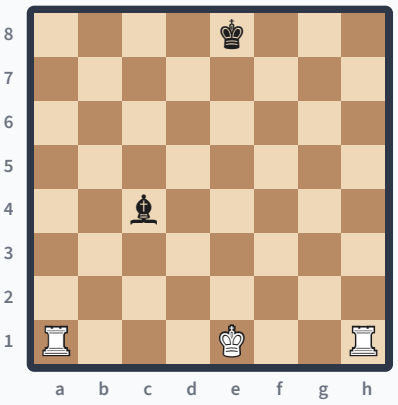
**Lesson 9 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **Can White castle? Which side: kingside, queenside, both or neither?**



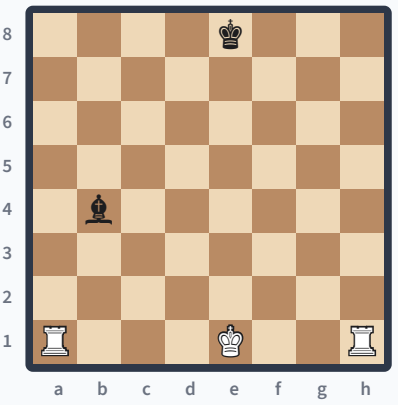
Answer:

**2** **Can White castle? Which side: kingside, queenside, both or neither?**



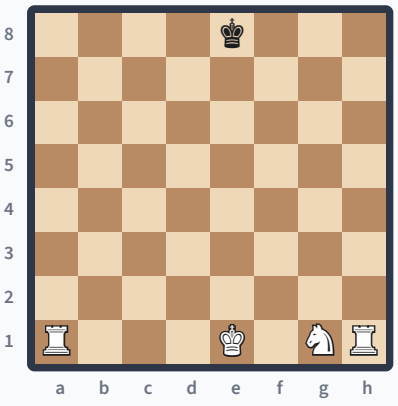
Answer:

**3** **Can White castle? Which side: kingside, queenside, both or neither?**



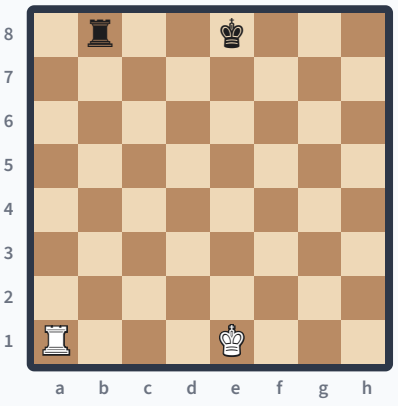
Answer:

**4** **Can White castle? Which side: kingside, queenside, both or neither?**



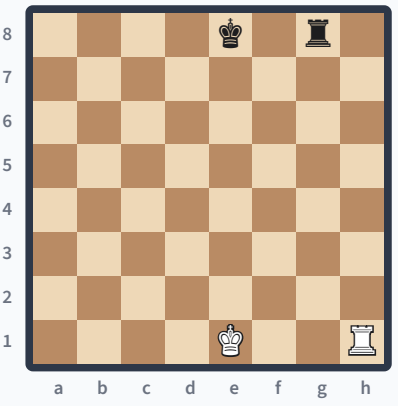
Answer:

**5** **Can White castle? Which side: kingside, queenside, both or neither?**



Answer:

**6** **Can White castle? Which side: kingside, queenside, both or neither?**



Answer:

**Tip:** check the squares the KING crosses and lands on. The Rook is allowed to cross an attacked square! **Score: ____ / 6**

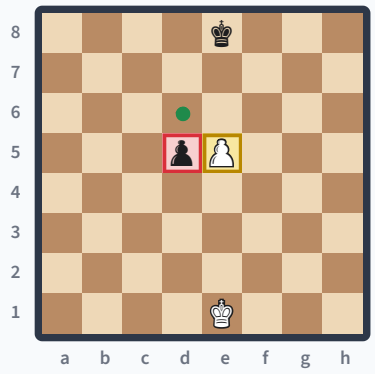
# EN PASSANT & PROMOTION

Two special pawn rules every player must know

**Lesson 10 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. En Passant: The Set-Up

"IN PASSING"

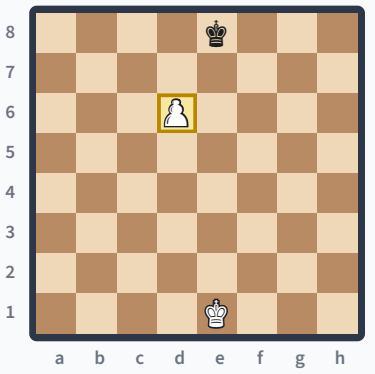


```
Black just played d7-d5
```

- Black's pawn jumped two squares and landed **right beside** White's pawn on e5.
- White may capture it **as if it had moved only one square**, landing on d6.

## 2. En Passant: The Capture

EXD6 E.P.

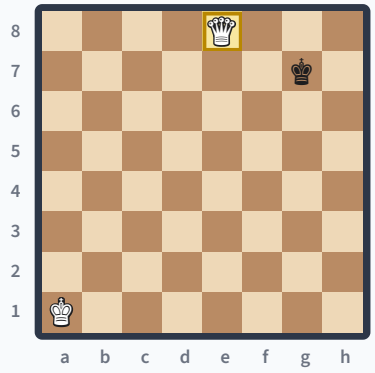


```
After 2.exd6 e.p.
```

- White's pawn moves to **d6** and Black's d5-pawn is taken off the board.
- Only allowed on the **very next move**. Wait one turn and the chance is gone.

## 3. Promotion

E8=Q

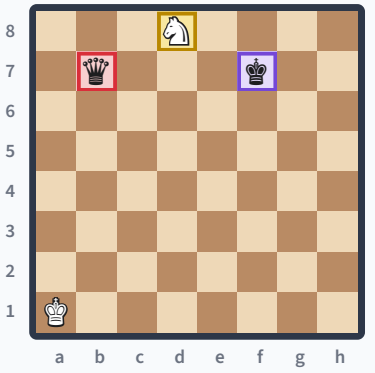


```
After 1.e8=Q
```

- A pawn on the last row is swapped for a **Queen, Rook, Bishop or Knight** (never a King).
- You can have two Queens or more! No spare Queen? Use an upside-down Rook.

## 4. Underpromotion

D8=N+! FORK



```
After 1.d8=N+! (then 2.Nxb7)
```

- Sometimes a **Knight** beats a Queen: here it gives check AND attacks the Queen on b7.
- Promoting to a Rook or Bishop can also avoid stalemate. Always check first!

## Special Pawn Rules in a Nutshell

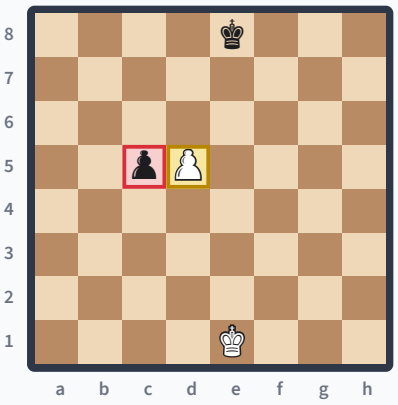
1. **En passant:** only a pawn can do it, only against a pawn that just jumped two squares past it, and only right away.
2. **Promotion:** any pawn reaching the last row MUST become a Queen, Rook, Bishop or Knight, your choice.
3. **Underpromotion:** choose a Knight for a fork or check, a Rook or Bishop to avoid stalemate.

# PUZZLES: SPECIAL MOVES

En passant and promotion in action

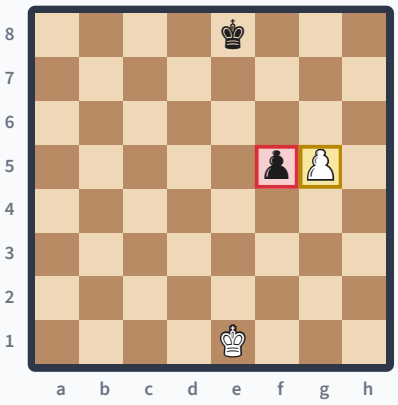
**Lesson 10 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **Black just played c7–c5. Write White's en passant capture.**



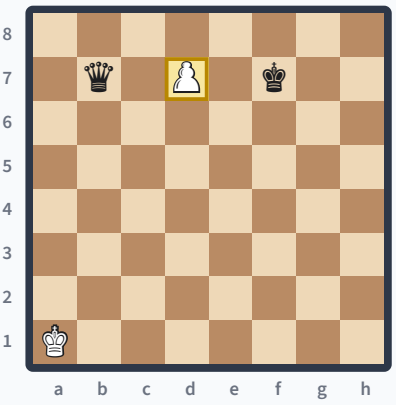
Answer:

**2** **Black's last move was f6–f5 (one step). Can White take en passant?**



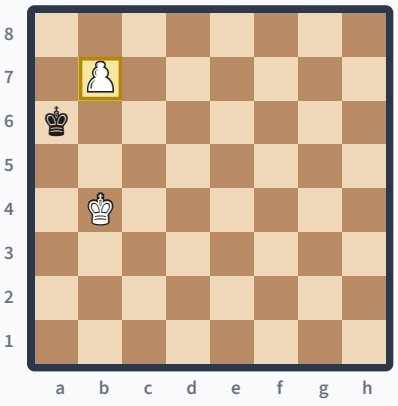
Answer:

**3** **White to move. Promote with a FORK! Which piece?**



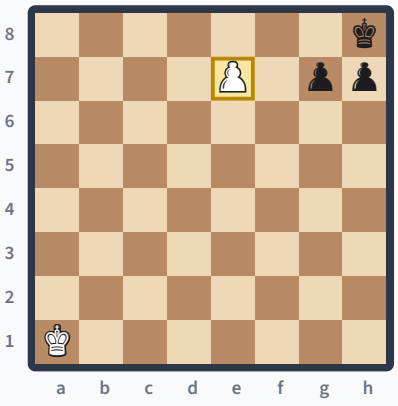
Answer:

**4** **White to move. Promote, but DON'T stalemate! Which piece?**



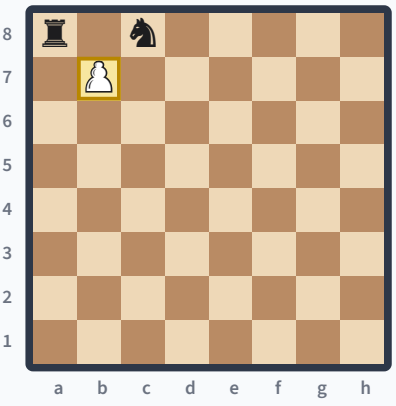
Answer:

**5** **White to move. Promote and checkmate in 1!**



Answer:

**6** **White to move. Which promotion wins the most?**



Answer:

**Tip:** before promoting, check: will my new piece give stalemate? Could a Knight fork?

**Score: ____ / 6**

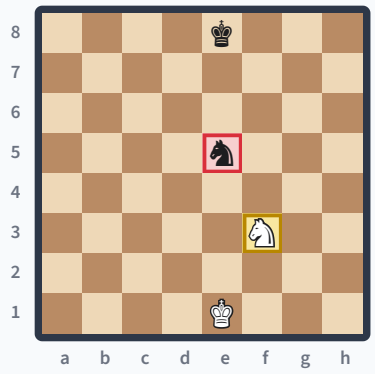
# IS IT SAFE?

Hanging pieces, counting and fair trades

**Lesson 11 · Defence**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Hanging Pieces

FREE TO TAKE

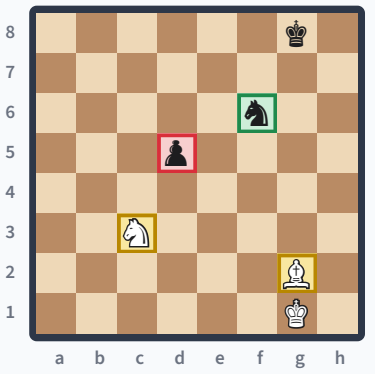


```
1.Nxe5: a free Knight!
```

- A piece that is attacked and **not defended** is "hanging". Take it!
- Before every move, also check: are any of **my** pieces hanging?

## 2. Count: 2 Attackers vs. 1

TAKE IT

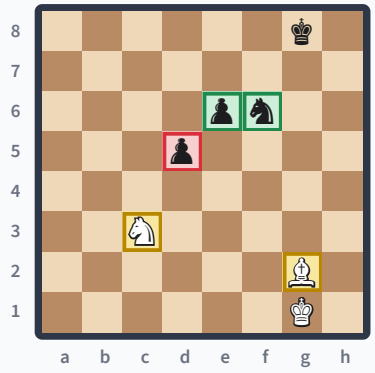


```
1.Nxd5 Nxd5 2.Bxd5
```

- Attackers on d5: **Nc3 + Bg2 = 2**. Defenders: **Nf6 = 1**.
- More attackers than defenders: the pieces swap off and White wins the pawn.

## 3. Count: 2 Attackers vs. 2

DON'T TAKE

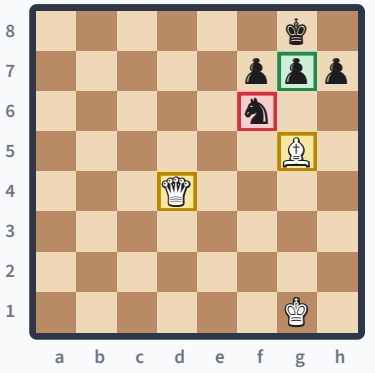


```
1.Nxd5? exd5 2.Bxd5 Nxd5
```

- Now d5 has **2 defenders** (e6-pawn + Nf6). The swap ends with Black taking last.
- White gives a Knight and a Bishop (6 points) for two pawns (2 points). Bad deal!

## 4. Cheapest Piece First

BXF6, NOT QXF6



```
Bxf6 = fair · Qxf6?? = bad
```

- **Bxf6 gxf6**: Bishop (3) for Knight (3), a fair trade.
- **Qxf6?? gxf6**: Queen (9) for Knight (3). Always capture a defended piece with your **cheapest** piece.

### Before You Capture, Ask:

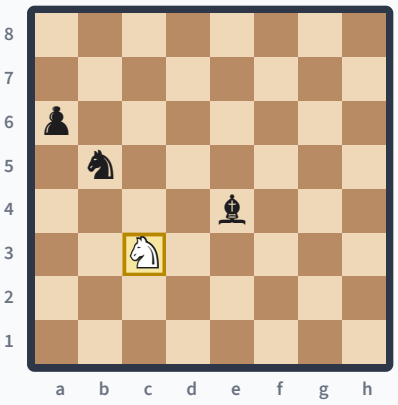
1. **Is it defended?** No defenders? It's hanging: take it (after checking it's not a trap!).
2. **Count** attackers vs. defenders. More attackers usually wins it; equal or fewer usually doesn't.
3. **Add up the points** you give and get: Pawn 1 · Knight 3 · Bishop 3 · Rook 5 · Queen 9.

# PUZZLES: IS IT SAFE?

Free pieces, counting and fair trades

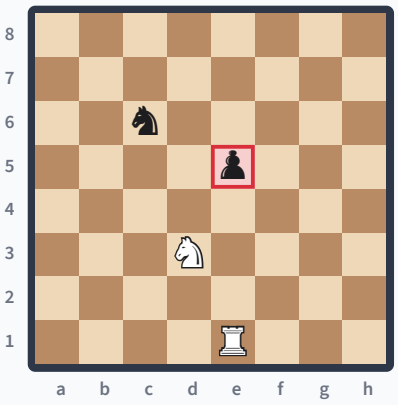
**Lesson 11 · Defence Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **White to move. Which Black piece can the Knight take for free?**



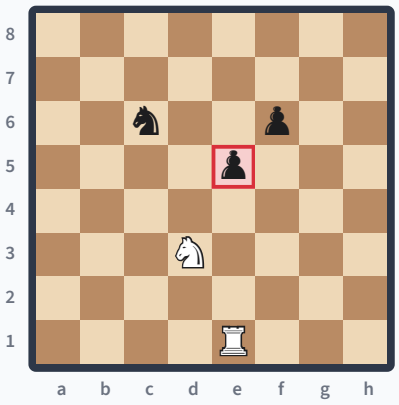
Answer:

**2** **White to move. Can White win the e5-pawn? Count!**



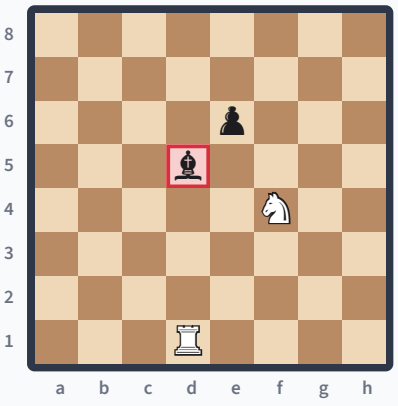
Answer:

**3** **White to move. NOW can White win the e5-pawn? Count again!**



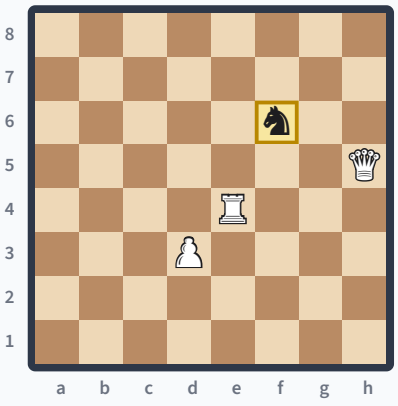
Answer:

**4** **White to move. Take the d5-Bishop: with the Knight or the Rook?**



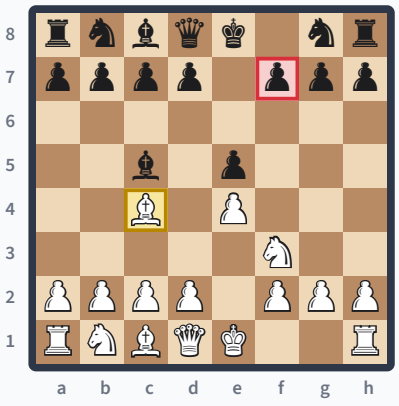
Answer:

**5** **Black to move. What can the Black Knight take for free?**



Answer:

**6** **White to move. Is 4.Bxf7+ a good idea? Count!**



Answer:

**Tip:** Pawn 1 · Knight 3 · Bishop 3 · Rook 5 · Queen 9. Count what you give and what you get!

**Score: ____ / 6**

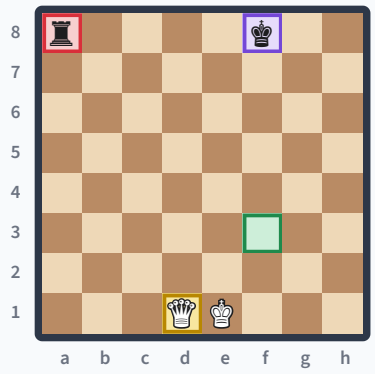
# CHECKS, CAPTURES, THREATS

The three questions to ask before every move

**Lesson 12 · Defence**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Checks

LOOK AT EVERY CHECK

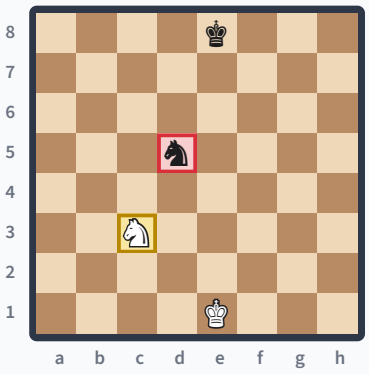


`1.Qf3+! and next 2.Qxa8`

- List **every check** you can give. Most do nothing, but one might win something!
- **1.Qf3+** checks the King AND attacks the Rook. The King must move, then take the Rook.

## 2. Captures

IS IT FREE?

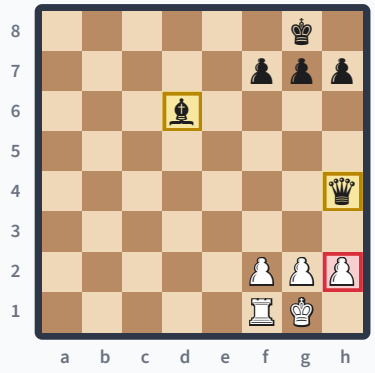


`1.Nxd5: nothing guards d5`

- List **every capture**. Then ask: is the piece guarded?
- Nothing guards the d5-Knight, so it is **free**. Take it!

## 3. Threats

WHAT DO THEY WANT?

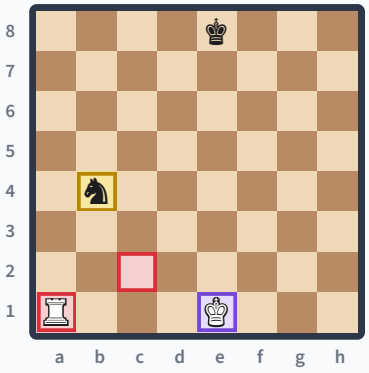


`Black threatens ...Qxh2#!`

- Before your own plan, ask: **what is my opponent trying to do?**
- Here Black wants **...Qxh2#**. Stop it with **1.g3** or **1.h3**.

## 4. Their CCT Too

THINK LIKE THEM



`Stop ...Nc2+: 1.Rb1 or 1.Kd2`

- Do CCT for your opponent: their **checks**, **captures** and **threats**.
- Black wants **...Nc2+**, forking King and Rook. Move the Rook, or guard c2 with the King.

### The CCT Routine

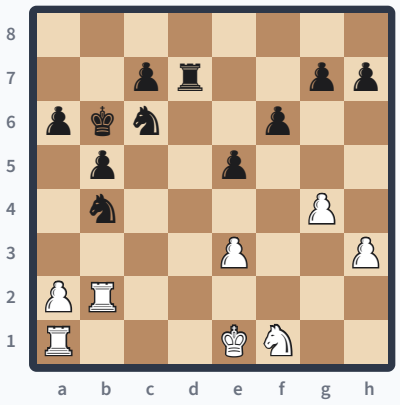
1. **Checks:** list every check, for you AND for your opponent.
2. **Captures:** list every capture. Is it free? Count attackers and defenders.
3. **Threats:** what does my opponent want to do next? Stop it first, then carry on with your plan.

# PUZZLES: CCT

Checks, Captures, Threats · six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 12 · Defence Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

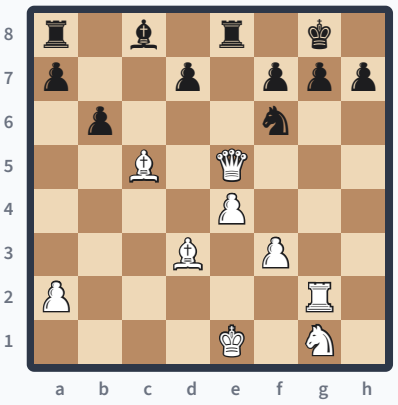
**1** **Black to move. Look at every check. Which one wins?**



White (1289) v Black (1701) · 7+9
lichess.org/CT49XZGj

Answer:

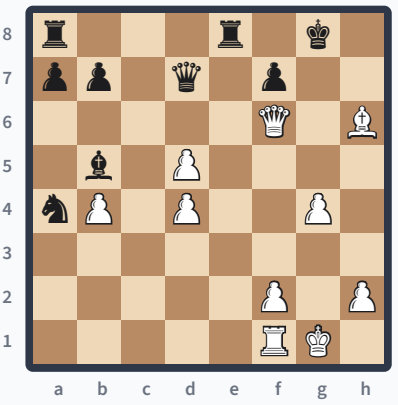
**2** **Black to move. Is anything free to take?**



White (1307) v Black (1631) · 10+0
lichess.org/6gcZ6qX7

Answer:

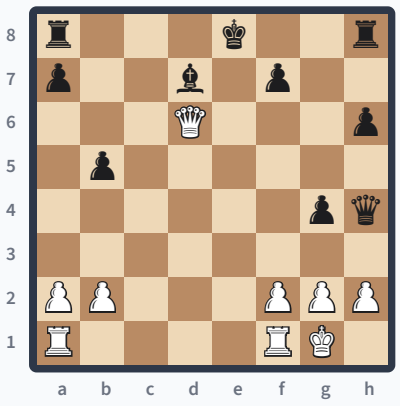
**3** **Black to move. What does your opponent threaten? Stop it!**



White (1169) v Black (1104) · 10+0
lichess.org/ZKQAL78x

Answer:

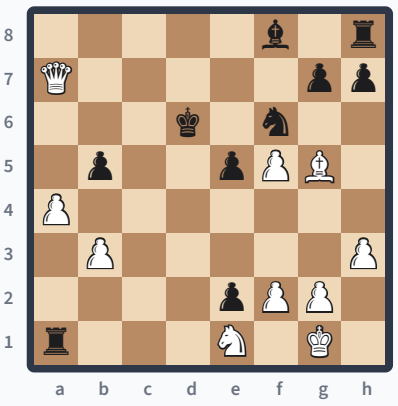
**4** **White to move. Look at every check. Which one wins?**



White (1662) v Black (1849) · 10+0
lichess.org/nLLl4gtH

Answer:

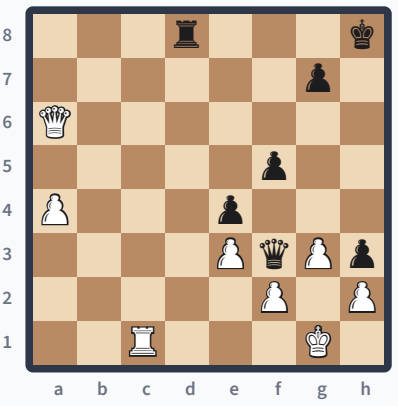
**5** **Black to move. Is anything free to take?**



White (1114) v Black (1384) · 10+0
lichess.org/R2Vnrli7

Answer:

**6** **White to move. What does your opponent threaten? Stop it!**



White (1733) v Black (1672) · 5+5
lichess.org/VzLpYJ1R

Answer:

**Tip:** go through the list every time: checks, captures, threats. For you AND your opponent.

**Score: ____ / 6**

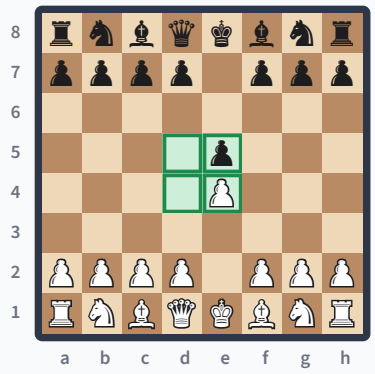
# THE OPENING

Phase 1 of 3 · Centre, develop, castle



## 1. Control the Centre

D4 E4 D5 E5

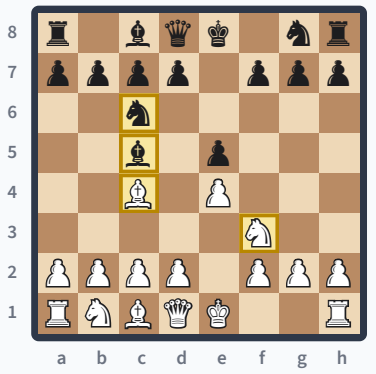


```
1.e4 e5
```

- The 4 middle squares are the most important on the board. Pieces there reach everywhere.
- Start with a **centre pawn** (e4 or d4) and aim your pieces at the centre.

## 2. Develop Your Pieces

KNIGHTS & BISHOPS OUT

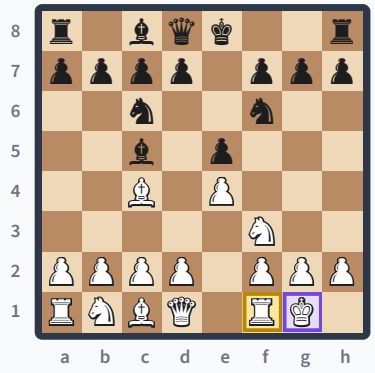


```
2.Nf3 Nc6 3.Bc4 Bc5
```

- Bring out **Knights and Bishops** first, toward the centre. Usually Knights before Bishops.
- Move each piece once. Keep the Queen at home for now.

## 3. Castle by Move 7

KING SAFE

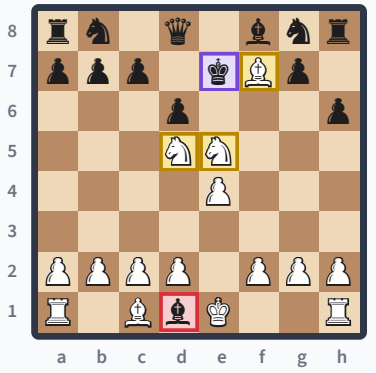


```
4.O-O Nf6
```

- Castling tucks the King behind a wall of pawns and brings a Rook toward the middle.
- A King left in the centre is an easy target. Aim to castle **within 7 moves**.

## 4. Warning: Legal's Mate

GREED LOSES



```
5.Nxe5! Bxd1?? 6.Bxf7+ Ke7 7.Nd5#
```

- After 1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 d6 3.Bc4 h6? 4.Nc3 Bg4, Black wasted a move and didn't develop the Knights.
- Black grabs the Queen, but White's Knights and Bishop mate. **Development beats greed!**

## Opening Checklist

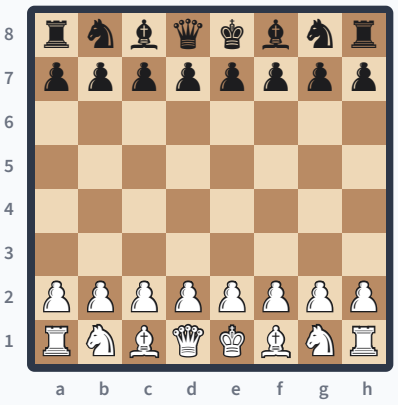
1. Put a **pawn in the centre** (e4 or d4).
2. **Knights and Bishops** out, toward the centre.
3. **Castle** within the first 7 moves.
4. Don't move the **same piece twice**.
5. Don't bring the **Queen** out early.
6. Before grabbing: **what is my opponent threatening?**

# PUZZLES: THE OPENING

Centre, develop, castle, and don't be greedy

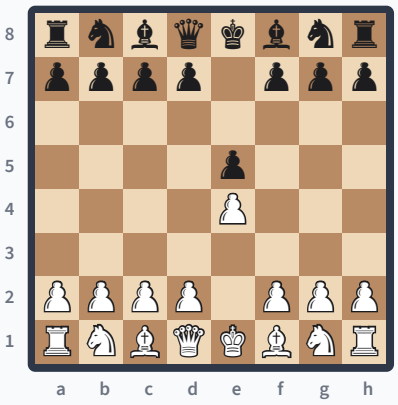


**1** Best first move for White? A) a4 B) e4 C) Na3



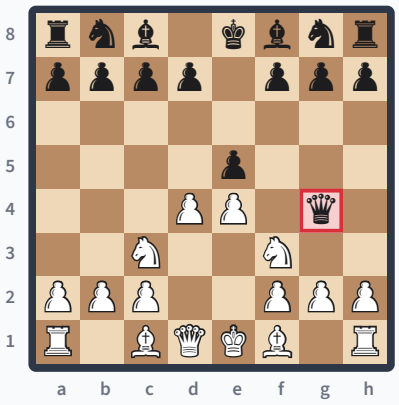
Answer:

**2** 1.e4 e5. Best 2nd move for White? A) Qh5 B) Nf3 C) a4



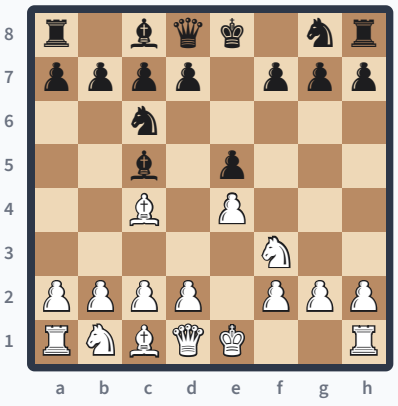
Answer:

**3** Black moved the Queen three times. Which opening rule did Black break?



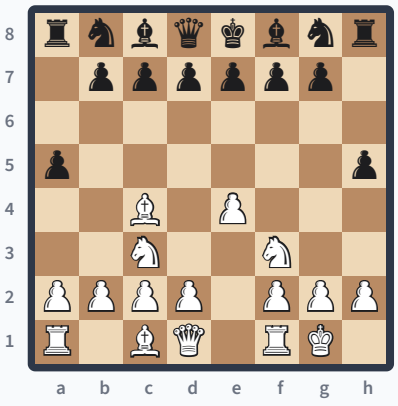
Answer:

**4** White to move. Can White castle kingside now? Why?



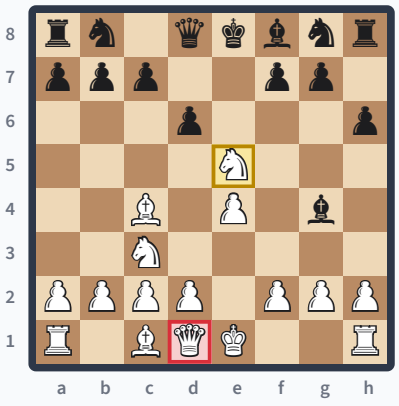
Answer:

**5** Which side is better developed? Count the pieces out!



Answer:

**6** Black to move. Should Black grab the Queen with 5...Bxd1?



Answer:

**Tip:** centre pawn, Knights and Bishops out, castle by move 7, Queen stays home.

**Score: ____ / 6**

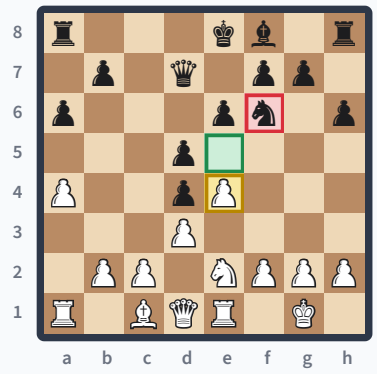
# THE MIDDLEGAME

Phase 2 of 3 · Make a plan and improve your position



## 1. Take the Centre and Space

MORE ROOM

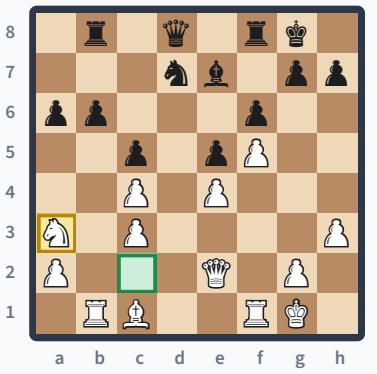


15.e5! Ng8 16.Nxd4

- **e5** takes space and chases the Knight back to g8.
- More space: more squares for you, fewer for them.
- White (1382) v Black (1522) · 10+5

## 2. Improve Your Worst Piece

WORST PIECE

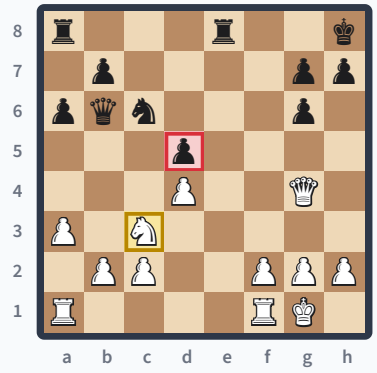


18.Nc2! b5 19.cxb5

- The Knight on **a3** does nothing: on the edge it has few squares.
- Give it a job: **Nc2** heads back to the centre.
- White (1580) v Black (1402) · 10+2

## 3. Find a Weakness

WEAK PAWN

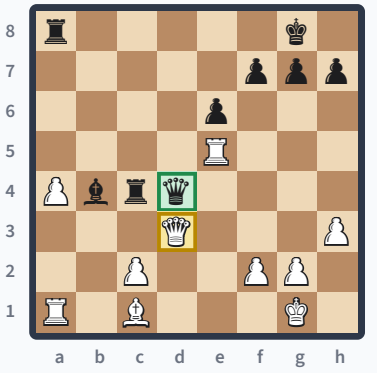


19.Nxd5! Qd8 20.c4

- No pawn can ever defend Black's **d5**-pawn.
- Attack it more times than it is defended, then take it.
- White (1694) v Black (1709) · 15+3

## 4. Think About the Endgame

QUEENS OFF



25.Qxd4! Rxd4 26.Be3

- White is a pawn up. With the Queens off, the extra pawn counts for more.
- Before a trade, ask: **is the endgame good for me?**
- White (1862) v Black (1690) · 10+0

## Middlegame Checklist

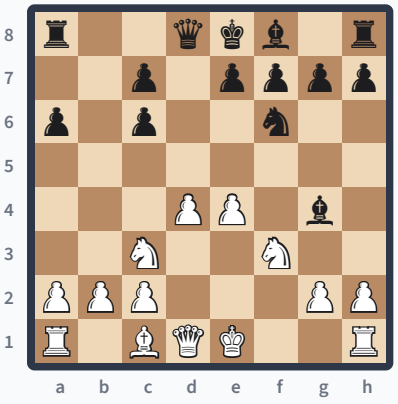
1. Take the **centre** and gain **space**.
2. Improve your **worst piece**.
3. Look for **weaknesses**: lonely pawns, loose pieces.
4. Attack a weakness **more times** than it is defended.
5. Trade when the **endgame** will be good for you.
6. Before every move: **CCT** (Lesson 12).

# PUZZLES: THE MIDDLEGAME

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 14 · Strategy Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

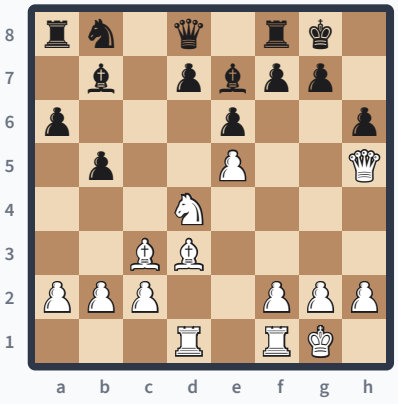
### 1 Black to move. Which pawn move is best?



White (1461) v Black (1402) · 15+15
lichess.org/0DDBKLQM

- [ ] **A)** 8...h6
- [ ] **B)** 8...e5
- [ ] **C)** 8...g6

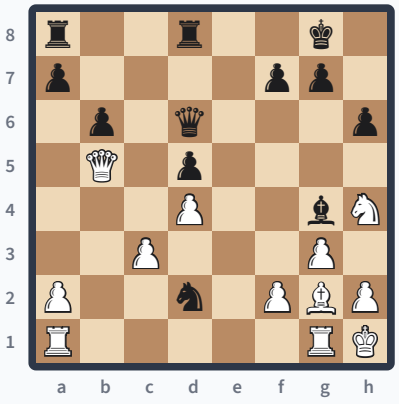
### 2 White to move. Which is White's worst piece?



White (1439) v Black (1390) · 10+0
lichess.org/smzTCkGH

- [ ] **A)** the Bishop on d3
- [ ] **B)** the Knight on d4
- [ ] **C)** the Rook on f1

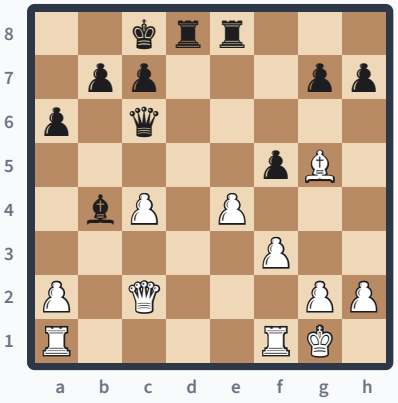
### 3 Black to move. Which is Black's worst piece?



White (1787) v Black (1500) · 8+0
lichess.org/pfetxTJL

- [ ] **A)** the Rook on a8
- [ ] **B)** the Bishop on g4
- [ ] **C)** the Knight on d2

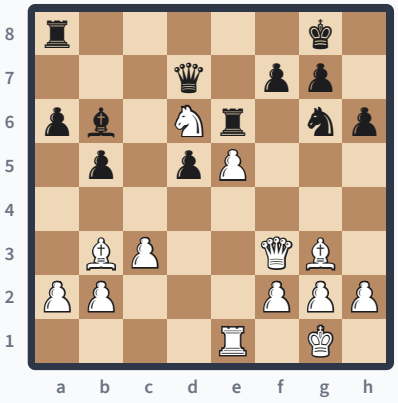
### 4 Black to move. Which white pawn is weak?



White (2008) v Black (1954) · 10+0
lichess.org/PyEpiSJp

- [ ] **A)** the pawn on f3
- [ ] **B)** the pawn on e4
- [ ] **C)** the pawn on c4

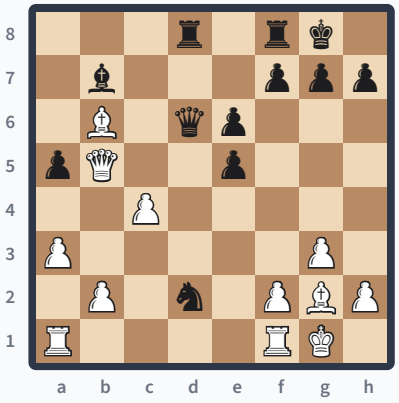
### 5 White to move. Which black pawn is weak?



White (1845) v Black (1846) · 10+0
lichess.org/pHJ5zXyE

- [ ] **A)** the pawn on b5
- [ ] **B)** the pawn on d5
- [ ] **C)** the pawn on h6

### 6 Black to move. Which trade is best?



White (2276) v Black (2230) · 10+5
lichess.org/Kx1DVz3N

- [ ] **A)** Queen takes Bishop on b6
- [ ] **B)** Bishop takes Bishop on g2
- [ ] **C)** Knight takes Rook on f1

**Tip:** Find the worst piece, the weakest pawn, and the trade that helps you.

**Score: ____ / 6**

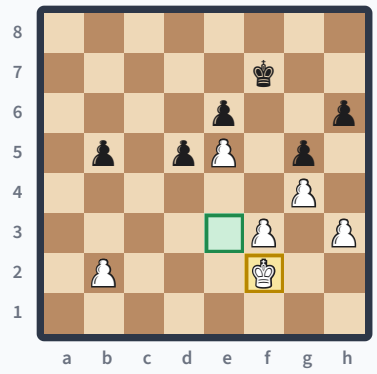
# THE ENDGAME

Phase 3 of 3 · King, passed pawns, active pieces



## 1. King to the Middle

KING = FIGHTER

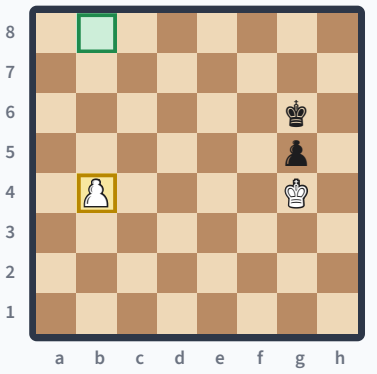


```
32.Ke3! Ke7 33.Kd4 Kd7 34.Kc5
```

- Queens gone? The King is safe: bring it to the centre.
- From d4 it walks to **c5** and attacks b5.
- White (1970) v Black (1506) · 10+0

## 2. Push the Passed Pawn

RUN!

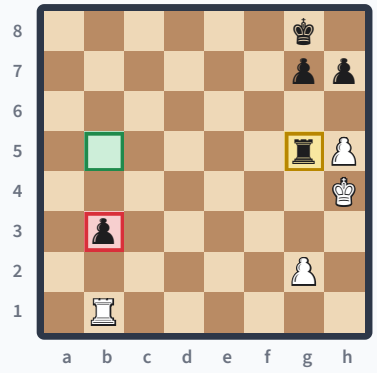


```
79.b5! Kf6 80.b6
```

- No black pawn in front or beside: the b-pawn is **passed**.
- The black King is too far. Push! Other moves only draw.
- White (1818) v Black (1849) · 10+0

## 3. Active Rook

BEHIND THE PAWN

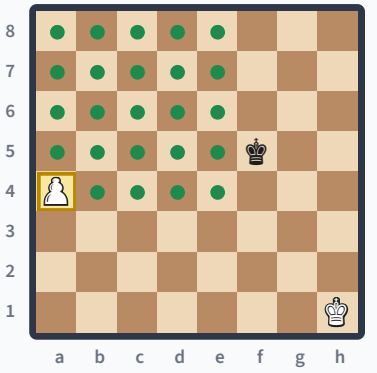


```
40...Rb5! 41.Rb2 Kf7
```

- Black's **b3**-pawn is passed: the Rook goes **behind** it.
- Active Rooks attack and help pawns; passive Rooks just wait.
- White (1203) v Black (1267) · 9+0

## 4. Count the Race

THE SQUARE



```
White to move: 1.a5! wins
```

- Draw a **square** from the pawn to its queening square. If the King can step into it, it catches the pawn.
- Black to move: 1...Ke5 steps in and catches it. White to move: after **1.a5!** the square shrinks and the pawn wins.

## Endgame Checklist

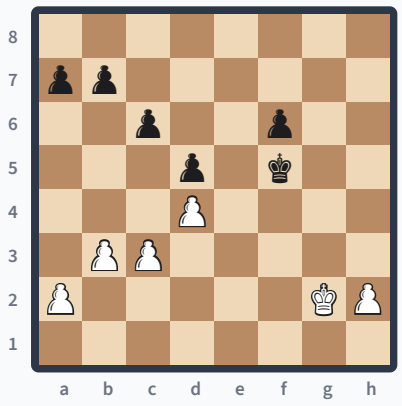
1. Bring your **King** to the centre.
2. **Push** passed pawns, with the King to help.
3. Rooks go **behind** passed pawns or to the 7th rank.
4. Count the race: use the **square** of the pawn.
5. A piece up? **Trade pieces**, keep pawns (Lesson 19).
6. Watch out for **stalemate** (Lesson 20).

# PUZZLES: THE ENDGAME

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 15 · Endgame Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

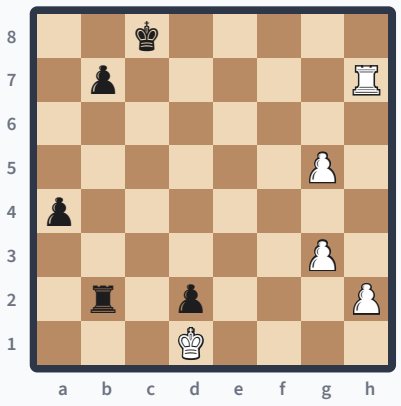
### 1 Find the best move for White!



White (1834) v Black (1699) · 10+0
lichess.org/DayPmf7b

Answer:

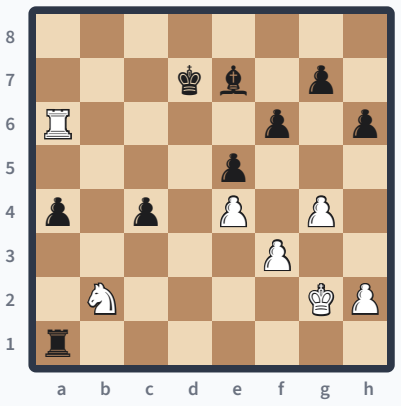
### 2 Find the best move for Black!



White (1477) v Black (1414) · 15+5
lichess.org/6aqXbVBC

Answer:

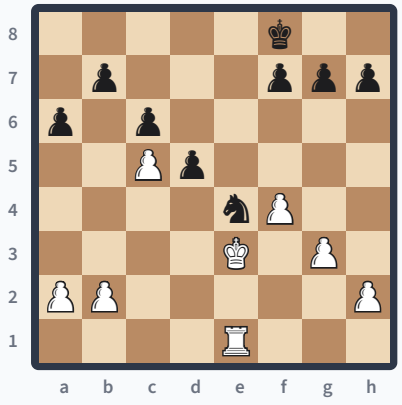
### 3 Find the best move for Black!



White (1729) v Black (1639) · 20+10
lichess.org/s2d0qppI

Answer:

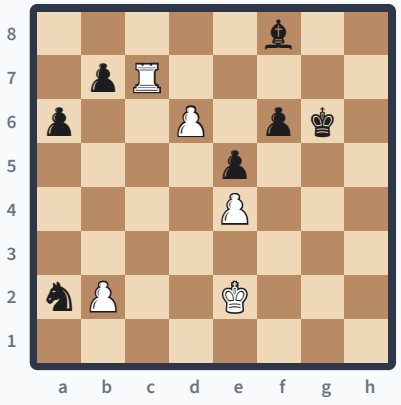
### 4 Find the best move for White!



White (1289) v Black (1455) · 10+0
lichess.org/LDoLJndl

Answer:

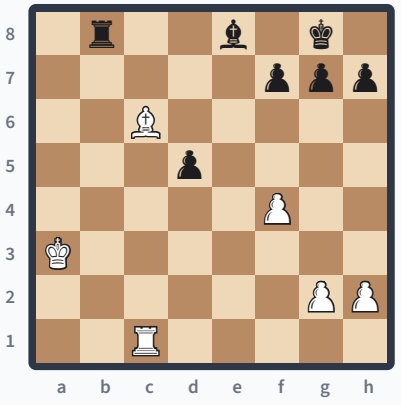
### 5 Find the best move for White!



White (1349) v Black (1306) · 10+0
lichess.org/RVdKnAU2

Answer:

### 6 Find the best move for Black!



White (1683) v Black (1621) · 10+0
lichess.org/X6AOrl95

Answer:

**Tip:** King to the centre, push passed pawns, and make your Rook active.

**Score: ____ / 6**

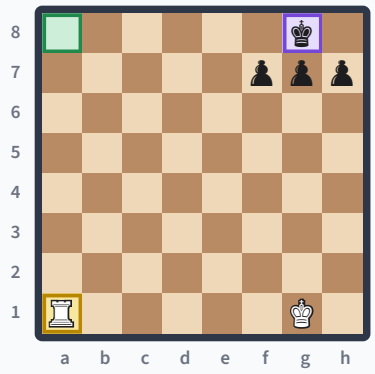
# MATE IN ONE

Spot the checkmate • Four patterns to know



## 1. Back-Rank Mate

ROOK ON THE LAST ROW

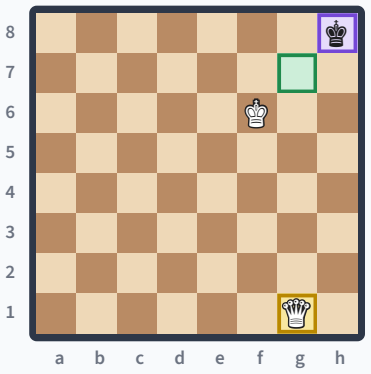


`1.Ra8#`

- Black's own pawns block the King in. A Rook on the back row is **checkmate**.
- Watch out for this against YOUR King too!

## 2. Kiss of Death

QUEEN + HELPER

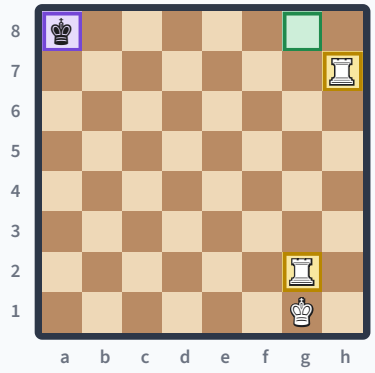


`1.Qg7#`

- The Queen goes right next to the King, **guarded by her own King**.
- The King can't take her, and every square around it is covered.

## 3. Two Rooks

ROOK + ROOK

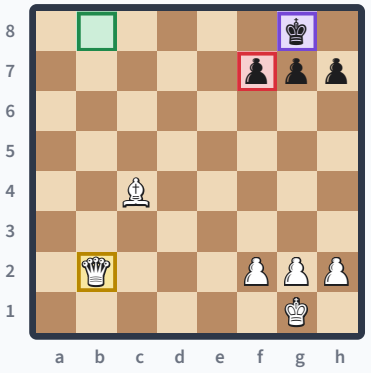


`1.Rg8#`

- One Rook guards the 7th row; the other checks on the 8th.
- This is the ladder mate you know, finished in one move.

## 4. Try Every Check

ONE CHECK IS MATE



`1.Qb8# (1.Bxf7+? is just a check)`

- White has two checks. **1.Bxf7+** lets the King take the Bishop.
- **1.Qb8#** is mate: the King has no square and nothing can block.

## Finding Mate in One

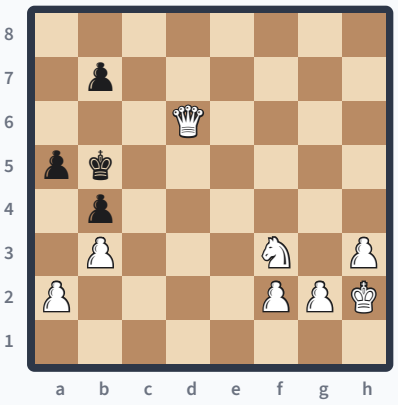
1. **List every check** you can give.
2. For each check, ask: can the King **move**, can something **block**, can the checker be **captured**?
3. Three times "no" means **checkmate**!

# PUZZLES: MATE IN ONE

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 16 · Attack Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

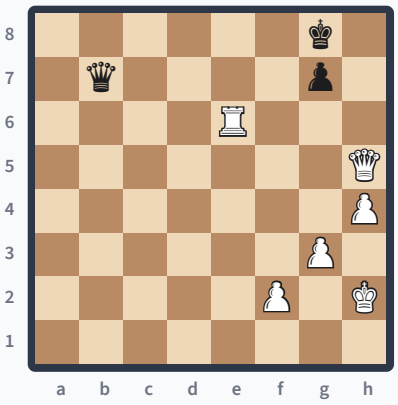
**1** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



White (1515) v Black (1379) · 10+0
lichess.org/atgsbOBS

Answer:

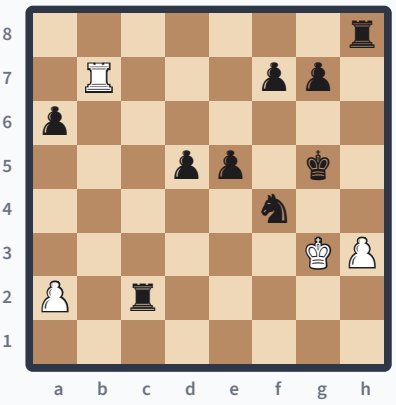
**2** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



White (2006) v Black (1960) · 10+0
lichess.org/yI6cT8yt

Answer:

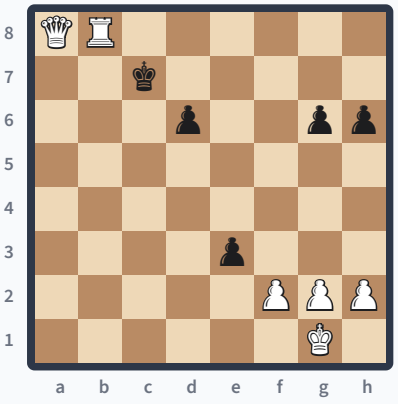
**3** **Black to move. Checkmate in 1!**



White (1537) v Black (1453) · 20+10
lichess.org/ooVLKWzi

Answer:

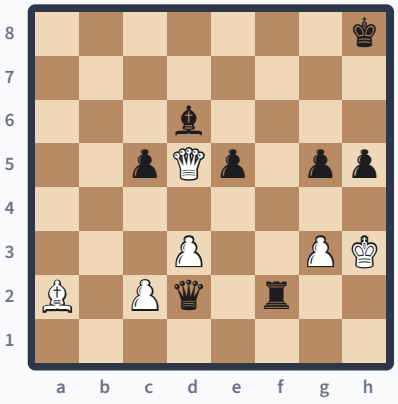
**4** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



White (2020) v Black (1788) · 10+0
lichess.org/B2PZqrvE

Answer:

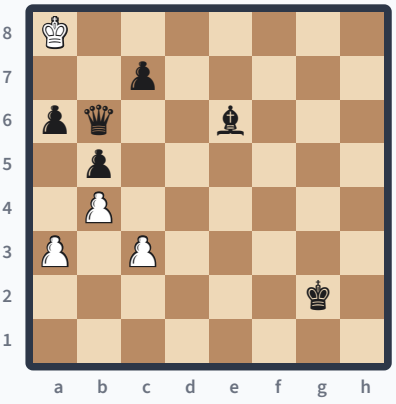
**5** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



White (1456) v Black (1472) · 8+0
lichess.org/RifoRB7V

Answer:

**6** **Black to move. Checkmate in 1!**



White (1646) v Black (1860) · 10+0
lichess.org/xiHZ2Yz5

Answer:

**Tip:** list every check, then ask: can the King move, block or capture? Three "no"s = mate!

**Score: ____ / 6**

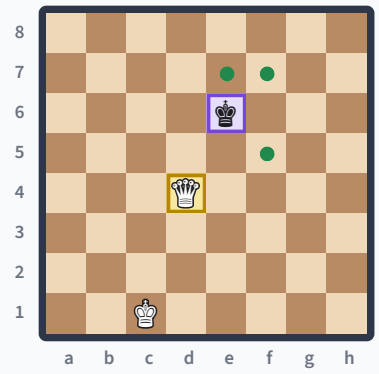
# QUEEN + KING CHECKMATE

Box the King in, walk your King over, then mate

**Lesson 17 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Build a Box

A KNIGHT'S JUMP AWAY

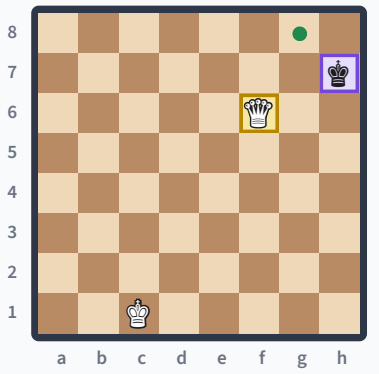


`Queen d4 vs. King e6`

- Put the Queen a **Knight's jump** away from the enemy King. It can't cross her lines (dots = its only squares).
- Each time the King moves, follow it, keeping that same Knight's-jump distance.

## 2. Squeeze to the Edge

NOW STOP THE QUEEN

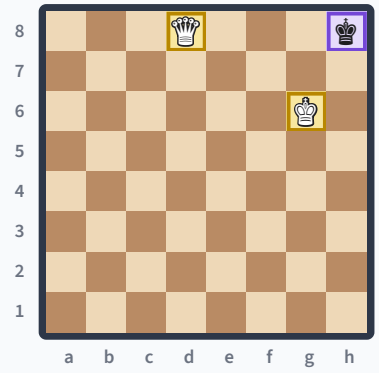


`Queen f6 vs. King h7`

- Keep shrinking the box until the King is stuck in the corner, going h7 → g8 → h7.
- Now **stop moving the Queen** and walk your own King over. The Queen can't mate alone.

## 3. Checkmate!

QD8#

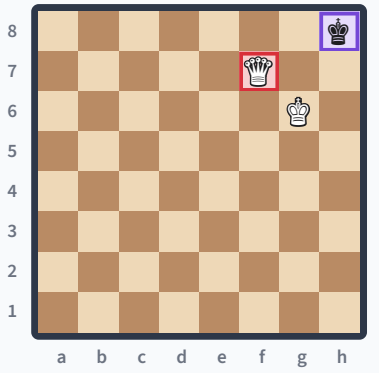


`Queen d5, King g6 → 1.Qd8#`

- Your King on **g6** guards g7 and h7. The Queen checks along the back row.
- **Qa8#** works too. Those are the only two mates here. Most other moves are stalemate!

## 4. Don't Stalemate!

QF7?? = DRAW



`Same position: 1.Qf7?? stalemate`

- Black is not in check, but g8, g7 and h7 are all covered. No legal move: **DRAW**.
- Qe6, Qc4 and even Kh6 are stalemate too. Before each move ask: "Check, or a square left?"

### The Queen Mate Recipe

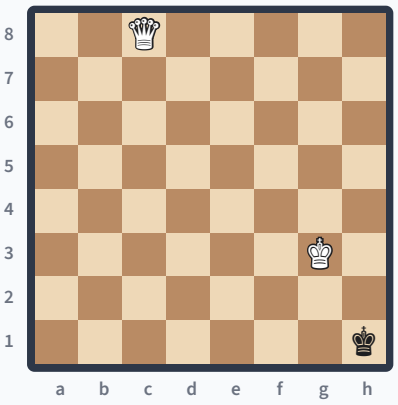
1. **Box:** Queen a Knight's jump from the King. Follow it and squeeze it to the edge.
2. **Bring the King:** once the enemy King is stuck on the edge, stop the Queen and march your King up.
3. **Mate, don't stalemate:** give check on the edge (or the Kiss of Death), and always leave a square until then.

# PUZZLES: QUEEN MATES

White to move and checkmate in 1. Don't stalemate!

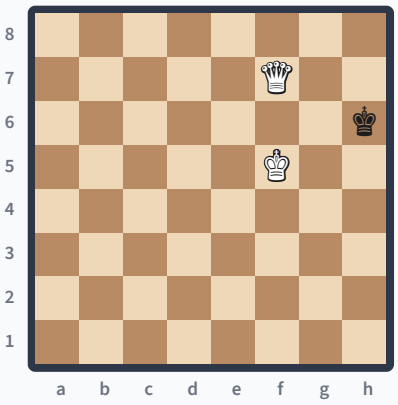
**Lesson 17 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



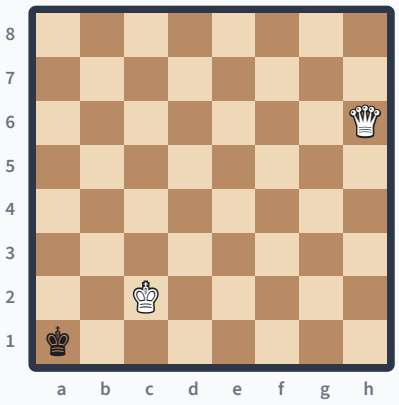
Answer:

**2** **White to move. Checkmate in 1! (Don’t move the King!)**



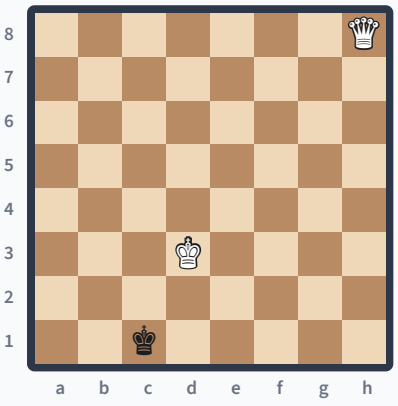
Answer:

**3** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



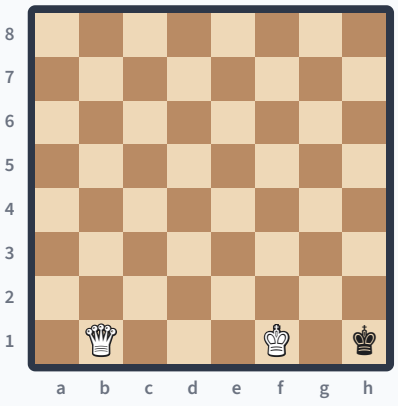
Answer:

**4** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



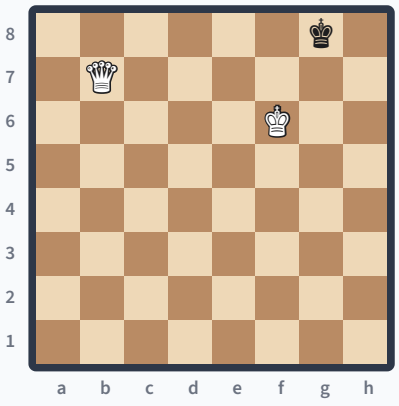
Answer:

**5** **White to move. Checkmate in 1! Watch out for stalemate!**



Answer:

**6** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



Answer:

**Tip:** a mate must be CHECK. If your move is not check and Black can't move, it's stalemate!

**Score: ____ / 6**

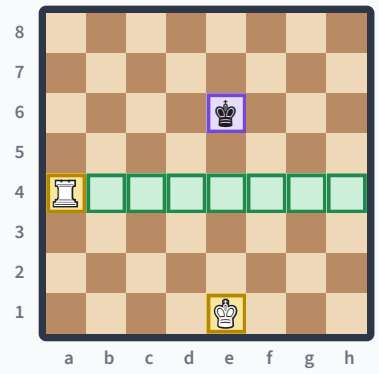
# ROOK + KING CHECKMATE

Cut off, face off, check • Push the King to the edge

**Lesson 18 · Basics**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Cut Off the King

A ROOK WALL

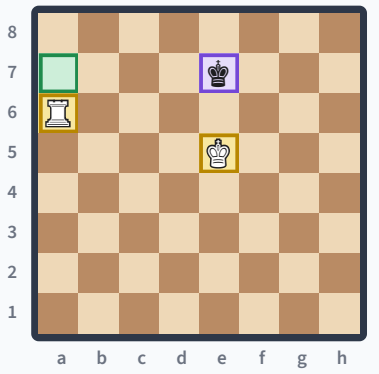


`Rook a4: King stays on ranks 5–8`

- The Rook on the 4th rank is a **wall**: Black's King can't cross it.
- Keep the Rook far from the enemy King, then march your own King up.

## 2. Kings Face Off, Rook Checks

1.RA7+

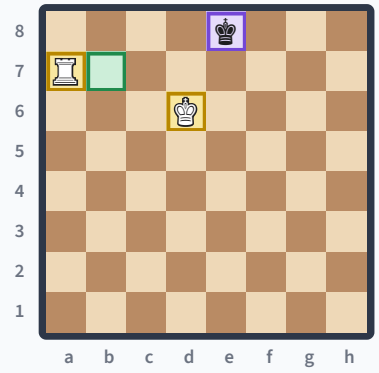


`White to move: 1.Ra7+`

- When the Kings **face each other** (e5 and e7), check with the Rook.
- Black's King must step back one row, to the 8th. Repeat until it's on the edge.

## 3. The Waiting Move

1.RB7! PASS

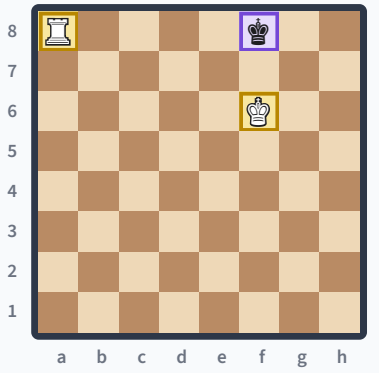


`1.Rb7! Kd8 2.Rb8#`

- Kings not facing each other? Don't chase: make a **quiet Rook move** along its row.
- If Black steps in front of your King (Kd8), mate! If 1...Kf8, walk your King across and repeat.

## 4. Checkmate!

RA8#



`After 1.Ra8#`

- Kings face each other (f6 and f8). Your King guards e7, f7 and g7.
- The Rook checks along the whole back row: no escape. Checkmate!

### The Rook Mate Recipe

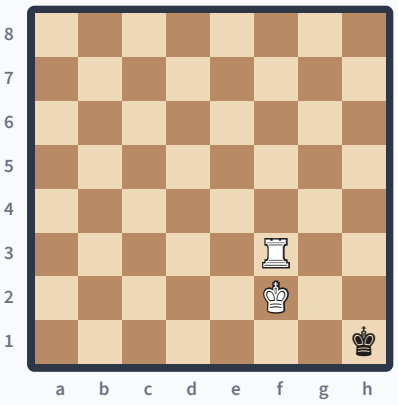
1. **Cut off:** use the Rook as a wall to trap the King in part of the board.
2. **Face off, then check:** bring your King in front of the enemy King, then check with the Rook to push it back one row.
3. **Waiting move:** if the King steps aside, make a quiet Rook move. Rook attacked? Move it far away along the same row.

# PUZZLES: ROOK MATES

Checkmate with King and Rook

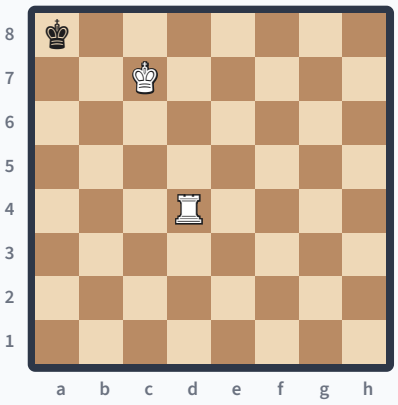
**Lesson 18 · Basics Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



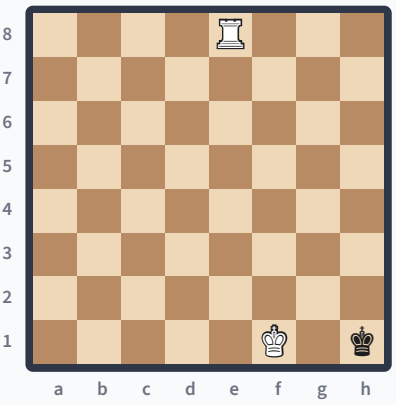
Answer:

**2** **White to move. Checkmate in 1!**



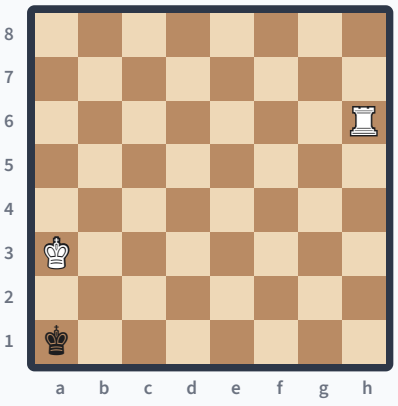
Answer:

**3** **White to move. Checkmate in 1! Watch out for stalemate!**



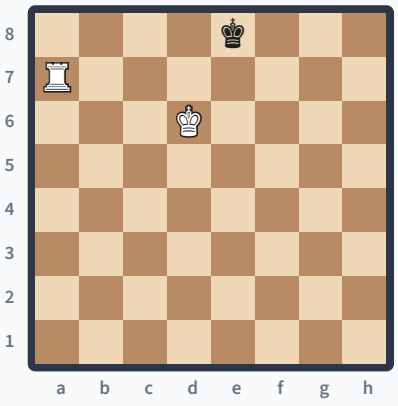
Answer:

**4** **White to move. Checkmate in 1! Watch out for stalemate!**



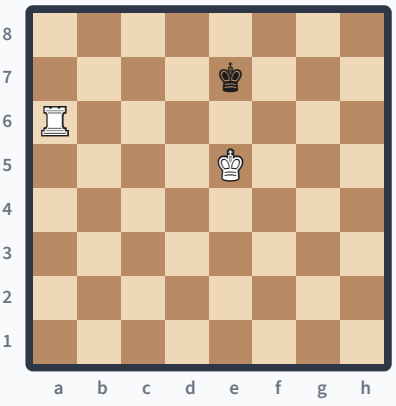
Answer:

**5** **Kings are NOT facing each other. Make a waiting move with the Rook.**



Answer:

**6** **Kings face each other. Which check pushes Black's King back?**



Answer:

**Tip:** Rook mates happen on the edge, usually with the Kings facing each other.

**Score: ____ / 6**

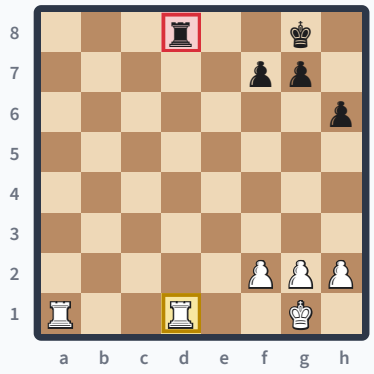
# WINNING WHEN YOU'RE AHEAD

You won a piece. Now finish the job!

Lesson 19 · Endgame
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Trade Pieces

SWAP DOWN

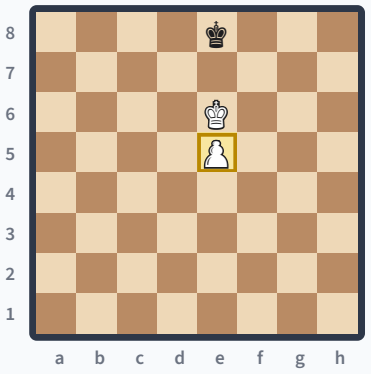


`1.Rxd8+ Kh7: a whole Rook up`

- With all the pieces on, an extra Rook is **44 points against 39**: only a small edge.
- After every trade it's Rook against nothing: an easy mate (Lesson 18).

## 2. Keep Your Pawns

PAWNS CAN QUEEN

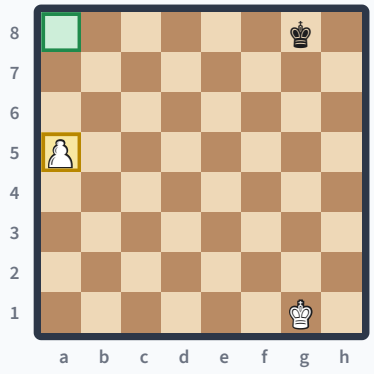


`King + pawn wins · King + Knight: draw`

- King + Knight (or Bishop) **can't checkmate**: a whole piece up can still be a draw.
- King + pawn can win: the pawn becomes a Queen. So **trade pieces, not pawns**.

## 3. Push the Passed Pawn

NOBODY CAN STOP IT

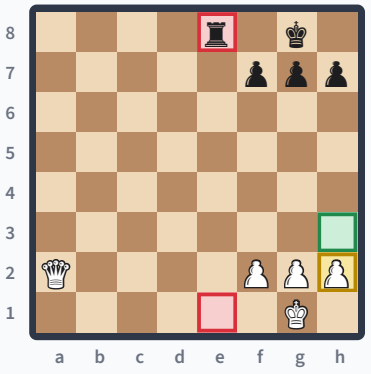


`1.a6! and the pawn runs to a8`

- A **passed pawn** has no enemy pawn in front of it or beside it.
- The black King is too far away to catch it. Push!

## 4. Don't Relax!

DO THEIR CCT



`Black threatens ...Re1#! 1.h3`

- White is a Queen up, but Black threatens **back-rank mate**. 1.h3 gives the King an escape square.
- Before every quiet move, check that the enemy King still has a move (**no stalemate!**).

## The Winning Recipe

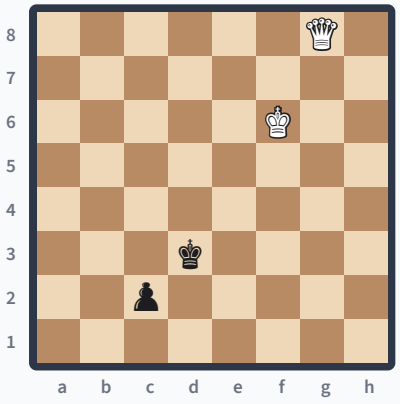
1. Stay safe first: do **CCT** for your opponent.
2. **Trade pieces**, keep your pawns.
3. Push a **passed pawn** to make a Queen.
4. Their passed pawn? Put a Rook **behind it** or on its queening square.
5. Go for **mate**.
6. Check for **stalemate** before every quiet move.

# PUZZLES: WINNING WHEN AHEAD

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 19 · Endgame Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

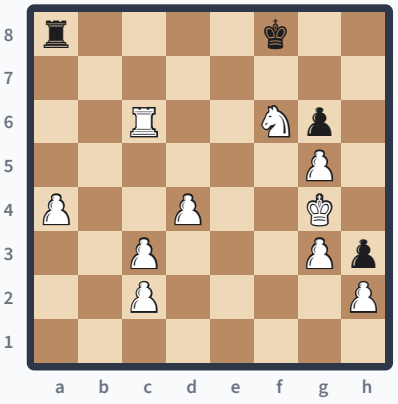
**1** **White is winning. Find the move that keeps it easy!**



White (1937) v Black (2090) · 10+0
lichess.org/zPwZcNlm

Answer:

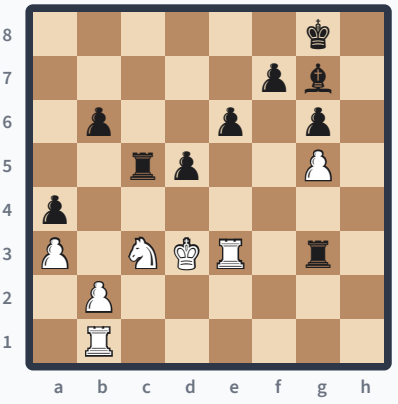
**2** **White is winning. Find the move that keeps it easy!**



White (1718) v Black (1581) · 10+0
lichess.org/dPuyBWEq

Answer:

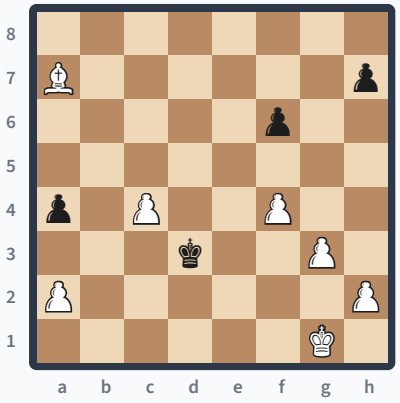
**3** **Black to move. You are ahead. Which trade is best?**



White (1856) v Black (1878) · 10+0
lichess.org/On1ePRj0

- ☐ **A)** Bishop takes Knight on c3
- ☐ **B)** Rook takes Rook on e3
- ☐ **C)** Rook takes Knight on c3

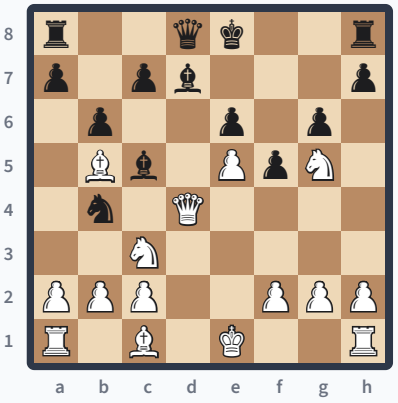
**4** **White is winning. Find the move that keeps it easy!**



White (1297) v Black (1319) · 10+0
lichess.org/uptBaJTj

Answer:

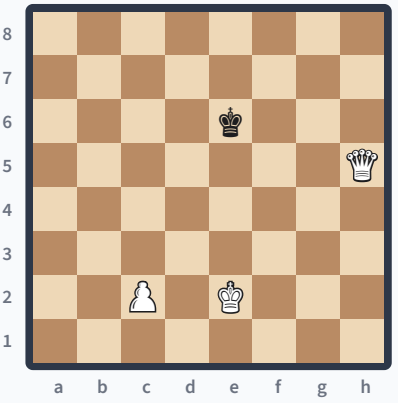
**5** **White to move. You are ahead. Which trade is best?**



White (1236) v Black (1137) · 10+0
lichess.org/xSDtl8vK

- ☐ **A)** Queen takes Knight on b4
- ☐ **B)** Bishop takes Bishop on d7
- ☐ **C)** Queen takes Bishop on c5

**6** **White is winning. Find the move that keeps it easy!**



White (1716) v Black (1850) · 10+0
lichess.org/HJSXS1DQ

Answer:

**Tip:** First stop their threats and their pawns, then trade pieces, push your pawn, and go for mate.

**Score: ____ / 6**

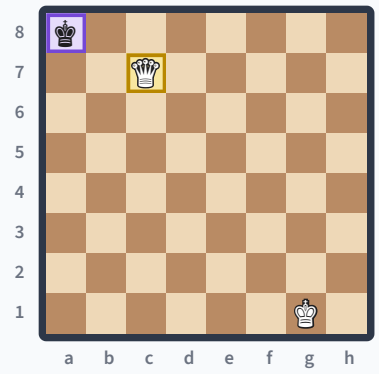
# HOW GAMES ARE DRAWN

Five ways a game ends with nobody winning (½-½)

**Lesson 20 · Defence**
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Stalemate

NO MOVES, NO CHECK

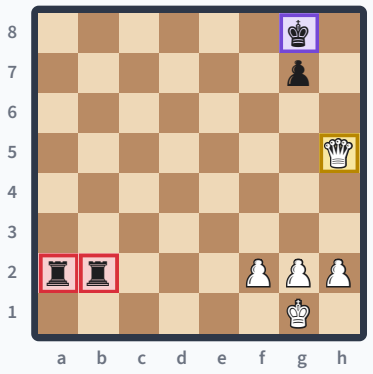


```
Black to move: stalemate
```

- The player to move is **not in check** but has **no legal move**.
- The game is over at once: a draw (see Lesson 8).

## 2. Repetition

SAME POSITION 3 TIMES

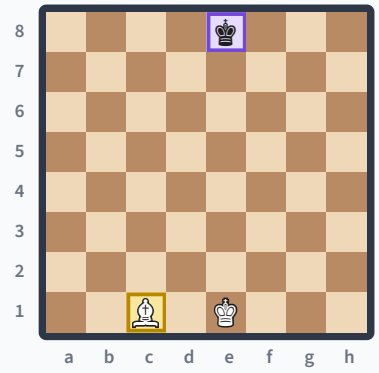


```
Qe8+ Kh7 Qh5+ Kg8 Qe8+ ...
```

- Black is two Rooks up, but White checks forever ("perpetual check"). Black can't escape.
- When the same position appears **3 times**, a player can claim a draw from the arbiter.

## 3. Not Enough Pieces

MATE IS IMPOSSIBLE



```
King + Bishop vs. King
```

- Some pieces can never checkmate: **King + Bishop**, **King + Knight**, or just two Kings.
- When checkmate becomes impossible, the game is a draw straight away.

## 4. 50 Moves & Agreement

TWO MORE WAYS

### The 50-Move Rule

If both players make **50 moves** in a row with **no capture** and **no pawn move**, a player can claim a draw. It stops a game going on forever when nobody can make progress.

### Draw by Agreement

1. Make your move on the board.
2. Say: **"Would you like a draw?"**
3. Press your clock.
4. Your opponent says yes, or just plays a move (that means no).

Some junior events don't allow draw offers. Check with the arbiter.

## Winning or Losing? Use the Draw Rules!

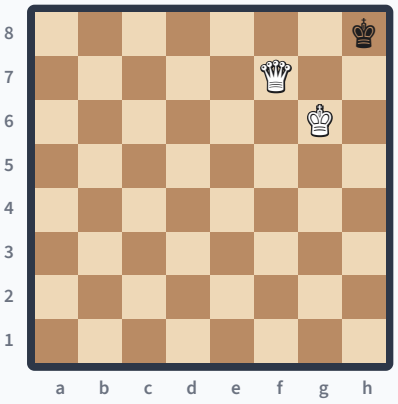
1. **When you're winning:** avoid stalemate, don't repeat moves, and keep capturing or pushing pawns to beat the 50-move rule.
2. **When you're losing:** look for a stalemate trick or a perpetual check. A draw is much better than a loss!
3. **Not sure if it's a draw?** Pause the clock and ask the arbiter.

# PUZZLES: DRAW OR NOT?

Is the game over? Who wins, or is it a draw?

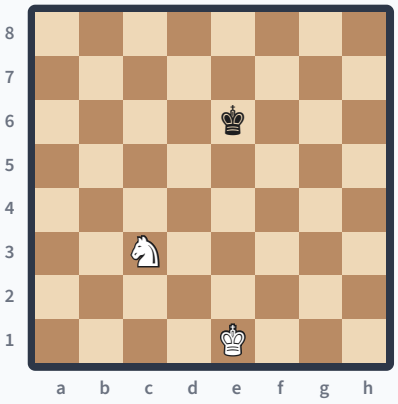
**Lesson 20 · Defence Puzzles**
Beginner Handouts

**1** **Black to move. Draw or not? Why?**



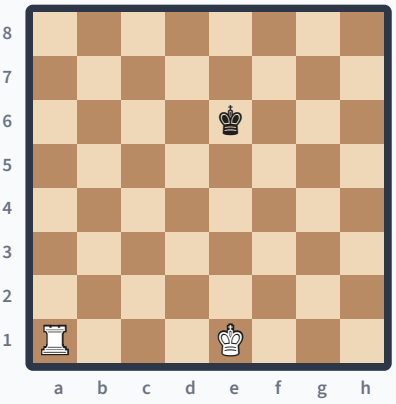
Answer:

**2** **Draw or not? Why?**



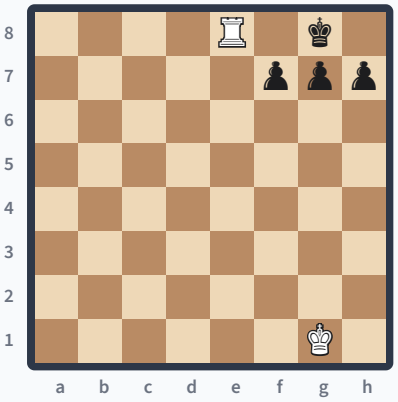
Answer:

**3** **Draw or not? Why?**



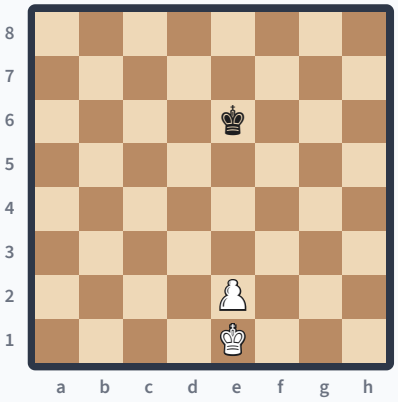
Answer:

**4** **Black to move. Draw or not? Why?**



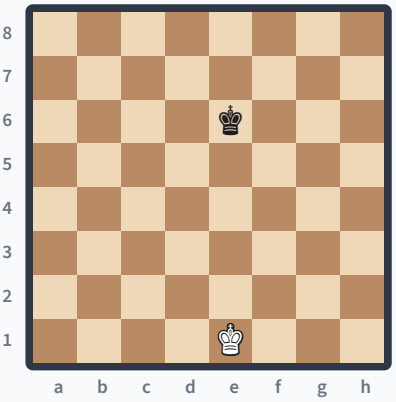
Answer:

**5** **Draw or not? Why?**



Answer:

**6** **Draw or not? Why?**



Answer:

**Tip:** check for stalemate, then ask: does anyone have enough pieces to checkmate?

**Score: ____ / 6**

# TOURNAMENT MANNERS

Touch-move, the clock and being a good sport

Lesson 21 · Rules
Beginner Handouts

## 1. Touch-Move

TOUCH IT, MOVE IT

- Touch one of **your** pieces: you must move it (if it has a legal move).
- Touch one of your **opponent's** pieces: you must capture it (if you can).
- Let go of a piece on a square: it **stays there**. No take-backs!
- Castling: touch the **King first**. Touching the Rook first means you must make a Rook move.

**Think with your eyes, not your hands. Sit on your hands if you need to!**

## 2. Fixing a Wobbly Piece

SAY IT FIRST

- A piece isn't centred on its square? Say **"I adjust"** (or "j'adoube") **before** you touch it.
- Only adjust on **your own turn**.
- Never adjust your opponent's pieces on their turn. Ask them, or ask the arbiter.

**Say:** "I adjust" → then touch

## 3. Using the Clock

MOVE, THEN PRESS

- Make your move, **then** press the clock, with the **same hand** you moved with.
- Press gently. No slamming, and keep your hand off the clock between moves.
- Write your move on the scoresheet after you have played it.
- If your time runs out, you usually **lose**, even with more pieces. Watch your clock!

## 4. Be a Good Sport

WIN OR LOSE

- **Shake hands** before the game and after it, whatever the result.
- To give up: say **"I resign"** and offer your hand. Don't just walk away.
- Phones and watches: switched **off** and in your bag.
- Won? Be kind. Lost? Say "well played" and learn from it.

## Good to Know

1. You **don't have to say "check"**. It's your opponent's job to notice.
2. **Promotion:** put the new Queen (or other piece) on the square before you press the clock. No spare Queen? **Pause the clock and ask the arbiter for one.** An upside-down Rook is a Rook, not a Queen!
3. Your opponent made an illegal move, or you're not sure of a rule? **Pause the clock and call the arbiter.**

# DURING THE COMPETITION

Food, quiet, problems at the board, and finishing your game



## 1. Food & Drink

WATER IS OK

- Bring snacks and drinks, but have them **away from the board** (in the break area).
- A bottle of **water** at the board is fine. Keep it on the floor or away from the pieces.
- No crumbs or sticky fingers on the pieces. Keep the table clean for everyone.

## 2. Quiet, Please

NO TALKING

- **No talking** during games: not to your opponent, friends, parents or coach.
- No helping others, and no asking for help.
- Finished early? Watch other games silently from a step away, or leave the playing hall.

**The only words you need: "I adjust", a draw offer, "I resign", and calling the arbiter.**

## 3. A Problem at the Board?

PAUSE · CALL · EXPLAIN

Your opponent kicks you under the table, talks too much, or something else feels wrong:

1. **Pause the clock.**
2. **Raise your hand** and call the arbiter.
3. **Explain calmly** what happened.
4. **Let the arbiter decide.** Don't argue with your opponent yourself.

## 4. When the Game Is Over

RECORD THE RESULT

1. **Pause the clock** and shake hands.
2. **Call the arbiter** (or go together to the results table).
3. **Check the result** is recorded correctly: 1-0, 0-1 or ½-½.
4. Both players **sign** the scoresheets if asked.
5. Set the pieces back up and leave quietly. Other games are still going!

## The Arbiter Is Your Friend

1. The arbiter is the referee. They are there to help you, and you will **never** get in trouble for asking.
2. Unsure about a rule, a draw, an illegal move or your opponent's behaviour? **Pause the clock and call.**
3. The arbiter's decision is final. Accept it politely and carry on playing.

# SOLUTIONS

All puzzle answers · Each game link is printed under its puzzle

No peeking until you've tried!

## 1. Setting Up the Board — p. 2

1 White King and Queen swapped (Queen goes on d1)
2 Board turned the wrong way (h1 must be light)
3 White c1-Bishop and c2-pawn swapped
4 Nothing wrong!
5 Black Knights and Bishops swapped
6 White Rooks and Knights swapped

## 2. Writing Down Your Game — p. 4

1 f5
2 A = b3, B = g6
3 d5
4 Nf3
5 Bxf7+
6 Qxf7# (Scholar's Mate!)

## 3. The Pawn — p. 6

1 exd5 (the e5-pawn is straight ahead, so it can't be taken)
2 No: it is blocked and has nothing to capture
3 Three: a3, a4 and cxb5
4 White: both need 5 moves, but White goes first
5 b6! If axb6 then c6!, if cxb6 then a6!, and a pawn breaks through
6 gxh8=Q: take the Rook AND get a Queen

## 4. The Rook — p. 8

1 Ten (b4 capture, c4, d4, f4, g4, h4, e5, e3, e2, e1)
2 Rxd6: the Knight is free (the h1-Bishop is guarded by the g3-Knight)
3 Three moves: Rxa5, Rxe5, Rxe8
4 Re7 attacks both the Bishop and the Knight
5 Rxg4 (the c4-pawn is guarded by b3)
6 Rb8#

## 5. The Bishop — p. 10

1 Never: c1 is a dark square and a8 is light
2 Ten (Bxb7, c6, c4, e6, f7, g8, e4, f3, g2, h1)
3 Bxb7 wins a free Rook (the f3-Knight is guarded by the g4-pawn)
4 Bc4 attacks the Rook and the Knight
5 Bxh3 (the c4-pawn is guarded by b3)
6 Bd5#

## 6. The Queen — p. 12

1 Twenty-four (including Qxb6)
2 Qh5 attacks the Rook on f3 and the Knight on f7
3 Qxg7 wins a free Bishop (the d8-Rook is guarded by the b7-Knight)
4 Qg7# (Kiss of Death)
5 Qxa5 (d3 is guarded by e2, g5 by h4)
6 Qd8# or Qa8#

## 7. The Knight — p. 14

1 Four moves (for example a1-c2-e3-d1-b2)
2 Four: c3, f2, g3, g5 (its own pawns block the rest)
3 Nc4 attacks the Rook and the Bishop
4 Nc6+! Check to the King, and the Queen on e5 falls next move
5 Six moves
6 Nf7#

## 8. The King — p. 16

1 Stalemate: not in check, no legal move, so it's a draw
2 Checkmate
3 Check: the King escapes to h7
4 No! The f4-Knight protects the Queen and the King has no square: checkmate
5 Kd1, Kd2, Kf1, Kf2 (move), Bxe5 (capture), Ne2 (block)
6 Rd8#

## 9. Castling — p. 18

1 Yes, both sides
2 Queenside only: the Bishop attacks f1, which the King must cross
3 No: White is in check
4 Queenside only: the Knight on g1 is in the way
5 Yes, queenside! b1 is attacked, but only the Rook crosses it, which is allowed
6 No: the King would land on g1, attacked by the Rook

## 10. En Passant & Promotion — p. 20

1 dxc6 (en passant)
2 No: en passant is only allowed right after a TWO-square pawn move
3 d8=N+! It checks the King and attacks the Queen
4 b8=R (b8=Q?? is stalemate!)
5 e8=Q# (e8=R# also mates)
6 bxa8=Q: take the Rook AND get a Queen

## 11. Is It Safe? — p. 22

1 Nxe4: the Bishop is free (the b5-Knight is guarded by the a6-pawn)
2 Yes: 2 attackers vs 1 defender. Nxe5 Nxe5 Rxe5
3 No: now it's 2 vs 2 (the f6-pawn joined in)
4 Nxd5! Knight for Bishop is fair. Rxd5?? exd5 loses the Rook
5 Nxh5 wins the Queen! (the e4-Rook is guarded by d3)
6 No: 4...Kxf7, and White gave a Bishop (3) for a pawn (1)

## 12. Checks, Captures, Threats — p. 24

1 32...Nd3+ 33.Ke2 Nxb2: a fork
2 27...Rxe5: the piece was unguarded
3 White threatens Qg7#. 28...Qxg4+ is the only move
4 18.Qe5+ Qe7 19.Qxh8+: a fork
5 26...Rxe1+: the piece was unguarded
6 Black threatens ...Qg2#. 33.Qf1 (or Kf1)

## 13. The Opening — p. 26

1 B) e4: it takes the centre and lets the Queen and Bishop out
2 B) Nf3: it develops a piece and attacks e5
3 Don't bring the Queen out early / don't move the same piece again and again
4 Yes: King and Rook haven't moved, f1 and g1 are empty and safe, so O-O
5 White: 3 pieces out and castled. Black has only moved pawns
6 No! 5...Bxd1?? 6.Bxf7+ Ke7 7.Nd5# is Legal's Mate

## 14. The Middlegame — p. 28

1 B) 8...e5: it takes the centre
2 C) the Rook on f1: it has almost no squares. 13.Rfe1 brings it into play
3 A) the Rook on a8: 20...Rac8 brings it to the c-file
4 C) c4: no pawn can defend it. 18...Rd4 attacks it
5 B) d5: no pawn can defend it. 21.Bxd5 wins it
6 B) 20...Bxg2: it removes White's best Bishop. A loses the Queen, C is worse too

## 15. The Endgame — p. 30

1 40.Kf3! the King heads for the centre (other moves only draw)
2 38...a3! push the passed pawn (other moves are worse)
3 38...Ra2! the active Rook attacks the Knight on b2
4 30.Kd4! the King comes to the centre
5 36.d7! push the passed pawn (other moves are worse)
6 26...Rc8! the Rook takes the open c-file and attacks the Bishop

## 16. Mate in One — p. 32

1 44.Nd4#
2 51.Re8#
3 37...Rxh3#
4 35.Qb7#
5 45.Qg8#
6 50...Bd5#

## 17. Queen + King Mate — p. 34

1 Qc1# (Qc5?? is stalemate)
2 Qg6# (Kf6??, Kf4?? and Kg4?? are stalemate)
3 Qa6# (Qe6?? is stalemate)
4 Qa1#
5 Qh7# (Qc2??, Qb2??, Qa2?? and Qb8?? are stalemate)
6 Qg7# (Kiss of Death)

## 18. Rook + King Mate — p. 36

1 Rh3#
2 Ra4#
3 Rh8# (Re2?? is stalemate)
4 Rh1# (Rb6?? is stalemate)
5 A far-away Rook move along the 7th row, e.g. Rh7 or Rb7. If 1...Kd8, then Rh8# (or Rb8#)
6 Ra7+ pushes the King back to the 8th row

## 19. Winning When You're Ahead — p. 38

1 63.Qg5! stops the pawn: c1 is covered
2 38.d5! push the passed pawn
3 B) 38...Rxe3+ 39.Kxe3 d4+: Rooks off, and the pawn forks King and Knight
4 31.c5! push the passed pawn
5 B) 12.Bxd7+ Qxd7 13.Qxd7+: Bishops off, then Queens. A and C lose the Queen
6 56.Qg6+! box the King in, then mate

## 20. How Games Are Drawn — p. 40

1 Draw: stalemate
2 Draw: King + Knight can't checkmate
3 Not a draw: King + Rook can checkmate, so keep playing
4 Not a draw: it's checkmate, White wins
5 Not a draw yet: the pawn could promote, so keep playing
6 Draw: only the Kings are left